

Paradox: The Traveller: Chapter 1

By Kyle Young

Prologue: The Prophecy of Parallax

In one of the ancient tales of the Seer, it was whispered that the universe did not erupt from a mere burst of energy. Still, it was instead woven into existence by five celestial beings, each an embodiment of a distinct type of magic—the fundamental elements of creation.

Soul magic (green): This magic dwells within every creature, forming the essence of their being. Known as green magic, it binds the soul to a spirit animal. Those gifted in soul magic can harness their bonded creature's powers to augment their abilities or in the hands of the truly powerful, summon these creatures to aid in battle or provide companionship.

Time magic (blue): Blue magic flows through the continuum, shaping our journey from one moment to the next. While glimpsing the past is within reach for many, altering it—travelling back in time, pausing, or hastening events—remains a formidable challenge. Central to time magic is the mastery of one's time stream, a hidden current that, if understood, allows one to manipulate the length and quality of their existence.

Reality magic (red): Red magic moulds the physical world. It grants its wielders the power to transform matter, changing one substance into another with a mere thought. Though altering existing forms is feasible; creating something entirely new demands immense strength and skill, as does porting across the spans of space.

Life magic (white): The essence of existence, white magic, governs the forces of life. Simple healing comes naturally to its practitioners, but reviving the dead or invoking new life from the void approaches the boundaries of impossibility without mastery over both life and death itself.

Death magic (black): Also known as black magic, it emerges naturally at the cusp of death. This enigmatic and perilous magic thrives on the life force of others, allowing its masters to commune with the dead or extend their own lives at the cost of another's vitality. In the hands of a supreme adept, it holds the terrifying power to extinguish thousands of lives in an instant.

Together, these beings crafted a multiverse, each nurturing their own universes. Yet over eons, they grew weary as they watched civilisations repeat the same mistakes. In their desire for change, they created Parallax—a being capable of controlling any entity across the multiverse to prevent self-destruction. However, their creation backfired when Parallax chose domination over guidance, stripping beings of their free will.

In desperation, four of the magical entities—Life, Reality, Soul, and Time—forged an alliance against Parallax. Recognising his immense power, they gathered an army from across time and space, sparking the Dark War. Victory was hard-fought, and though they could not destroy Parallax, they managed to imprison him in a hidden reality, sealing away their powers into objects to guard them against misuse.

Legend holds that Parallax will return, heralded by two dark beings, and only a group of heroes—the guardian, the king, the traveller, the survivor, the watcher, and the thief—can hope to oppose him. But the prophecy foretells that their success will come at a great cost.

Chapter 1: Echoes of a Kingdom

Genesis, Merlin's School, Year 3, 22 November, 10 pm

Hope fled the crowded hall, the sounds of laughter and celebration fading as she escaped into the cool night. The wooden bench near the edge of the garden called to her, a refuge from the chaos of her eighteenth birthday party—a party she no longer felt was hers. This year, like the ones before, she shared the day with everyone except Noah, Charlie, Edward, and Evan. But the weight of those absent and what was lost made her heart ache.

She slumped onto the bench, clutching a delicate necklace with trembling hands. The locket swung open to reveal a tiny picture of her family, a frozen moment from a life that now felt impossibly far away. Tears blurred her vision, spilling onto her cheeks as she stared at the image. It had been years since she'd seen them, yet the ache hadn't dulled.

Noah followed her outside, his sharp eyes catching her small figure hunched against the bench. The sight of her crying hit him like a blow, and he approached softly, his steps crunching on the gravel.

'Hope?' he called gently, his voice barely louder than the whisper of the wind.

She didn't look up but held the necklace tighter as if drawing strength from it. Noah sat beside her, his presence a silent offering of comfort. He didn't ask what was wrong; he knew. Instead, he stood and extended his hand towards her with a lopsided grin.

'Dance with me,' he said, his voice light though his heart felt heavy for her.

She looked at him, confusion knitting her brows. 'Noah, I don't—'

'Please,' he interrupted softly, a flicker of their shared saying lighting his gaze.

'As the birds sing . . . '—Hope hesitated, her lips trembling, before completing it in a broken whisper—'the skies open to show us the way home.'

She allowed him to pull her to her feet. Slowly, he twirled her under the open sky, the nebula above casting an ethereal glow over them. He hummed softly, guiding her into a rhythm only they could hear. The weight of her sorrow began to lift, just slightly, as they swayed in the night.

For a moment, she let herself smile. 'You're ridiculous,' she murmured, resting her head against his shoulder.

‘I’ve been told,’ Noah said, his voice warm. ‘But I’d rather be ridiculous than see you sad.’

The moment felt perfect until Noah’s gaze flickered to the edge of the garden. There beyond the comforting light of the nebula, a shadow loomed. It was human-like, but not a formless figure that seemed to shift with the wind. It stood motionless, watching.

Noah froze, his breath hitching. His heart raced, a memory rising unbidden of the day his father had passed away when he’d first seen it, *the monster*. It hadn’t come closer then, but it hadn’t gone either. The sight of it now twisted his gut, an unease clawing at him.

‘Noah?’ Hope’s voice pulled him back, her hands gripping his. ‘What’s wrong?’

He forced a smile, shaking his head. ‘Nothing,’ he lied. ‘Let’s go back inside.’

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom of Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 2am

The sky erupted in a vivid blaze of green as Camelot’s magical shield strained under the fury of the dragon’s relentless assault. The ground trembled with the beast’s wrath, shaking the castle to its core. In the dim confines of Guinevere’s chamber, tension clung to the air like a heavy fog. Lohengrin’s trembling fingers pressed against Guinevere’s pale skin, searching for a pulse, his movements deliberate yet fragile. Beneath the weight of Galahad’s restless pacing, the old wooden floorboards groaned louder with each step, echoing his growing despair.

‘Galahad, cease your pacing!’ Lohengrin’s voice broke the strained silence, taut with concentration.

Galahad stopped, his eyes piercing through the dim light as they fixed on Lohengrin. ‘How long does she have?’ he demanded, urgency seeping into every word.

Lohengrin, his face lined with exhaustion and the shadow of grief dulling his eyes, shook his head. ‘I do not know,’ he whispered, his voice a fragile thread of defeat. His hands, still faintly glowing with the remnants of white magic trembled. ‘But . . . not long.’

‘Can’t you give her more time?’ Galahad’s voice cracked, desperation creeping through his voice as his hands clenched into fists.

Lohengrin’s gaze drifted to the cold stone walls, his lips curling into a wistful smile as a tear slid down his cheek. ‘I could, but we both know that’s not what she wants.’

Galahad fell silent, his thoughts swirling like a storm until a sudden cough from the bed jolted him from his turmoil. Guinevere’s frail hand reached out, clutching Lohengrin’s trembling fingers. Her voice, barely audible, was laced with affection. ‘My sons, though we gather under such grim circumstances, I’m glad to call you family.’

Galahad wiped his eyes, his voice low as he whispered, ‘Thank you for taking us in.’

Lohengrin, his tone filled with gratitude, added, 'After my parents' deaths, you taught me what family truly means.'

Galahad stepped towards the foot of the bed, his voice softer now. 'Thank you for everything you've done.'

Guinevere's faint smile brightened the room, warming their hearts. 'My boys,' she said, her voice tender, 'come here.' She lifted her arms, weak but welcoming, and the two men embraced her gently. Lohengrin blinked back his tears as he held her close. After a long moment, they released her, and Galahad vowed, 'We will protect the kingdom.'

Guinevere nodded, her eyes soft with trust. 'I know you will.' Then with concern, she asked, 'Where is Loholt?'

Galahad and Lohengrin exchanged a glance before Galahad answered, 'I know where he is. I'll fetch him.'

As Galahad stormed through the echoing halls towards the stairs, a flash of green light halted him in his tracks. He turned to the window, his breath catching at the sight of the dragon. Its massive wings stretched wide, its copper scales gleaming under the night sky as it battered the castle's defences with a roar that shook the very stones. The shield shimmered, defiant under the creature's wrath.

'Foolish beast,' Galahad muttered with a hollow laugh. 'After five years, and still you attack, not knowing you'll never breach our walls.' Shaking his head, he continued his descent.

As he passed, the humble servant William was carrying a jug of water for the queen. Galahad barely acknowledged him, consumed in his thoughts. William moved like a ghost, unnoticed, until he reached Guinevere's chamber.

Pausing outside the door, William overheard Lohengrin's voice, heavy with regret. 'I should have taken that poison myself.'

Guinevere's reply was soft but firm. 'Lohengrin, I am old. I've lived my life. I don't need more time. You have a young family. Your life is just beginning.'

With his curiosity piqued, William leaned closer, but the door suddenly swung open and he stumbled inside.

Lohengrin and Guinevere turned towards him, their expressions softening as he awkwardly righted himself. Ignoring Lohengrin's impatience, William quietly approached the bed, setting the jug on the small table beside Guinevere.

'William,' Guinevere said gently, her eyes bright with mischief despite her frailty, 'have you asked Margaret out yet?'

William smiled shyly, shaking his head. 'No, not yet, my lady.'

Guinevere reached out and took his hand, her touch warm. 'When Arthur asked me out, it was in a much darker time. But the only thing that truly matters is that you ask. A question not asked is a path never taken.'

William's smile widened, and he nodded. 'You're right. Thank you.'

Turning to Lohengrin, Guinevere's eyes sparkled with curiosity. 'And how did you ask Belaye to go out with you?'

Lohengrin chuckled softly. 'Badly. Everything went wrong, but . . . she loved that I tried.'

William, emboldened by their words, picked up the second cup on the table and said, 'Thank you for your advice.' With a respectful nod, he slipped out of the room, closing the door quietly behind him.

William slipped into the adjacent room, once Arthur's but now abandoned, its corners heavy with dust and the weight of forgotten memories. He closed the door quietly behind him, pressing a cup to the wall in a bid to overhear the conversation between Lohengrin and Guinevere. The floor creaked under Lohengrin's shifting weight as he stood, his voice low but filled with frustration. 'How will I find my family without you? I still don't understand what all these ingredients from the quests are for.'

Guinevere, weak but composed, sat up slightly, her eyes distant with knowing. 'I know what we're making,' she said, her voice steady despite the strain, 'and I believe I know who it's for.'

Lohengrin stopped pacing and turned to her, his brow furrowed. 'How?' he asked.

Guinevere took a breath before beginning, 'You may have been taught by Merlin and Nimue—' but she was interrupted by a fit of coughing. When she recovered, she continued, 'But I knew them longer. Merlin spoke of a potion—one that could wipe the memory of an entire kingdom.'

Lohengrin stepped closer, disbelief clouding his face. 'Are you accusing Loholt? Your own son?'

Guinevere's expression was filled with regret. 'Think about it. During the Malazan invasion, all those he killed—wizards who could take on anyone's face—they still resent him for the lives he took. But if they couldn't remember . . .'

Lohengrin sat beside her, the bed creaking under his weight. 'So that's why he left,' he murmured, realisation dawning in him. 'He discovered this memory poison but knew he needed a wizard to gather the ingredients.'

Their conversation was abruptly halted as the door creaked open. Both Lohengrin and Guinevere turned towards it, falling silent as if caught in a spell.

Several floors below, Galahad paused outside Merlin's chamber, his fingers tracing the cold stone wall until he pressed a hidden stone. The wall slid aside, revealing a secret room filled with old scrolls and forgotten texts. There Loholt sat deep in thought, his face hard with concentration as he pored over a scroll.

Tall and imposing, his deep brown eyes gleamed with a mix of anger and contemplation. Loholt flinched as Galahad's voice cut through the silence. 'What are you doing down here? Your mother is dying upstairs, and you're hiding here—what, reading about a future that may never come to pass?' The accusation hung in the air, sharp as a blade.

Loholt's eyes flared with anger as he glared up at Galahad. 'I am the king. I do as I please. Right now, I believe I've found a prophecy—about me. I will stay here until I decipher it,' he snapped, his defiance palpable.

Without hesitation, Galahad grabbed Loholt by the shoulder, dragging him towards the stairs. The prophecy scroll fell from Loholt's grip, colliding with an invisible barrier before tumbling to the floor, forgotten.

As they neared Guinevere's chamber, Galahad's grip softened. His voice, now gentler, urged him, 'I cannot force you to go in, but as someone who had the chance to see my father one last time before he passed, I beg you—don't waste this moment. I was just a boy, but that day still haunts me.' With that, he opened the door and stepped inside.

Loholt stood frozen at the threshold, his hand trembling and his legs weakening. He took a steadying breath before summoning the strength to enter. Inside, Lohengrin stood by the bedside, his bloodshot eyes burning with grief. He turned sharply as Loholt entered, brushing past him and storming out.

Galahad followed him, closing the door quietly. 'Why did you leave?' he asked, his voice on the verge of breaking.

'She was always there for us,' Lohengrin began, his voice trembling. 'Whenever we needed her, she helped without hesitation. Now when I can save her, when I can help her, she won't even consider it.' His voice cracked, the weight of his frustration and despair hanging in the air.

'She misses Arthur,' Galahad said softly. 'She wants to be with him again. That's why she won't let you save her. You, of all people, understand that feeling.'

Lohengrin's magic began to swirl around him, a soft glow radiating from his body as his emotions surged. Tears welled in his eyes. 'I have the power to heal, to pull someone back from the brink of death,' he whispered, his voice raw with grief, 'but my mother is dying, and she won't let me save her. What's the point of this power if I can't use it for the people I love?'

Unable to hold back any longer, Galahad embraced him, and the two sank to the floor, their grief shared, as Lohengrin's sobs filled the air. They remained there, enveloped in the

warmth of their magic and the cold weight of their sorrow as the echoes of their loss filled the chamber.

As William lingered outside Guinevere's bedroom, he heard the quiet shuffle of footsteps and the soft click of the door as Lohengrin and Galahad left. Inside, Loholt moved slowly towards his mother, his steps heavy on the creaking floor. Guinevere's voice, though weak, cut through the silence. 'Loholt, why did you return home?'

Loholt sat down beside her on the bed, the old wood groaning beneath his weight. Gently, he touched her legs and said, 'Because you're getting old, and I wanted to see you one more time.'

Guinevere shifted uncomfortably, lifting her frail arms and silently asking for a hug. Loholt smiled and leaned in to embrace her. As they held each other, she patted him softly on the back, slipping something unseen into place.

Loholt pulled away and stood. 'I'll go bring Lohengrin and Galahad back,' he said, turning towards the door. But before he could leave, Guinevere's voice stopped him cold.

'What have you done to Lohengrin's family?'

Loholt froze mid-step. Slowly, he turned around, his expression darkening. 'What did you just say?'

Guinevere's gaze did not waver as she repeated, 'I asked, what did you do to Lohengrin's family?'

His hand clenched into a fist, anger rippling through him. 'I didn't do anything!' he snarled.

Guinevere's eyes softened with sorrow. 'I watched you grow up, Loholt. You don't think I'd recognise your handwriting? How you shape your Gs? After Lohengrin came to me after the second quest, I had a feeling it was you. I'm sorry . . . sorry that I brought a monster like you into this world.'

Loholt's face twisted with fury. Without warning, he grabbed a pillow from the bed and pressed it hard against Guinevere's face. She struggled beneath his grip, her hands flailing weakly as she fought to breathe. On the other side of the wall, William covered his mouth in horror, his heart pounding as Guinevere's struggles grew weaker and weaker until they stopped altogether.

Loholt stood up slowly, dropping the pillow. His breath was steady as if nothing had happened. He turned and walked towards the door with deliberate, heavy steps.

Outside, William sank to the floor, his body trembling. In a barely audible whisper, he muttered, 'Did Loholt just kill his mother?'

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Lublin, Poland, Year 1939, 27 September, 12am

A quaint two-storey house stood on the outskirts of Lublin, surrounded by a vast expanse of green fields that masked the creeping chaos. The world outside was crumbling, yet the serene surroundings seemed to defy the encroaching darkness. Inside, Edward, a young man poised between youth and adulthood, stood by the window. His sandy hair fell messily over his forehead as his worried eyes scanned the horizon, following distant figures appearing and disappearing against the bleak backdrop. His heart sank as he watched four shadowy figures sprint past the house, one momentarily locking eyes with him before vanishing into the void of uncertainty.

In the stillness that followed, Edward turned from the window and called for his mother. Angela, a figure of strength and solace, descended the staircase. Her presence had an innate power to calm, and her every step was deliberate and steady even as the world around them seemed to teeter on collapse. A bracelet on her wrist caught Edward's eye. The year 1935 was engraved on the metal and served as a haunting reminder of a happier time before war stole her husband and turned their lives into a tenuous fight for survival.

Edward's gaze lingered outside, but Angela moved to the phonograph, her actions deliberate as she selected her favourite vinyl. The soft, crackling melody of a familiar tune filled the room, gently dispelling the oppressive silence. With a soft smile, she took Edward by the hand and led him into the lounge. The two swayed to the music, their steps synchronised by an unspoken understanding that this brief dance was more than an escape—it was a defiant act of resilience. Angela's eyes sparkled, reflecting the bittersweet joy of cherished memories. She began to hum, threading her voice into the melody and creating a moment untouched by the war's shadow.

Their peace was shattered by a sudden, forceful knock at the door. Angela froze, her smile vanishing as fear clouded her face. The persistent knocking grew louder, more insistent, a harsh reminder of the dangers that loomed just beyond their threshold. Urgently, she ushered Edward into a hidden nook beneath the staircase, pressing a finger to her lips in a silent plea for silence.

When Angela finally opened the door, two Nazi soldiers barged in without hesitation. 'Who lives here?' one barked, his tone sharp and unyielding. The soldiers began tearing through the house, rifling through drawers and overturning furniture in a ruthless search. Edward, concealed in his hiding spot, could only watch through a narrow crack, his heart pounding with a mixture of fear and fury.

One soldier, his gaze keen and predatory, approached Edward's hiding place. Edward clenched his fists, powerless to act without exposing himself. Before the soldier could uncover him, Angela intervened, her voice steady despite the tremor in her chest. 'My son and husband were killed in the war during a bombing,' she said, her lie bold and unwavering.

The soldiers exchanged a sceptical glance. The bearded one grunted and ascended the stairs to continue searching. The other lingered, his eyes narrowing as he studied Angela. 'You're quite beautiful,' he murmured, stepping closer, his intentions unmistakable.

Angela took a step back, her discomfort evident, but the soldier grabbed her shoulder, pulling her towards him. 'This house is too big for just one person,' he whispered, his words laced with malice.

With fire in her eyes, Angela replied, 'There would be more if you weren't here.'

The soldier's expression darkened, his anger flaring, but before he could act, his companion descended the stairs. 'Let's go,' he muttered. As the bearded soldier left, the remaining one tightened his grip on Angela, unleashing violence upon her. Angela's screams pierced the air, each one cutting through Edward like a blade.

Anger erupted within Edward, a raw and untamed force that had long simmered beneath the surface. His hands began to glow with a mixture of red and green magic, the energy that pulsed with his anguish and rage. Unable to contain the power, Edward unleashed it, shattering the hiding nook as massive green wings sprouted from his back. He surged forward, his magic tearing through the floorboards and sending splinters into the soldier's chest.

The second soldier burst into the room, gun drawn, but Edward's magic bent the wood beneath his feet, transforming it into a protective shield of metal that deflected the bullet. With a cry of determination, Edward directed another surge of magic, sharp wooden shards flying through the air and felling the soldier.

As the chaos subsided, Edward turned to Angela. She lay on the ground, her dress stained with blood. A faint smile graced her face, even as life ebbed away. 'Edward,' she whispered, her voice a fragile thread, 'this world is full of angry people. Promise me you won't become one of them.'

Tears streamed down Edward's face as he cradled her in his arms. 'I promise,' he choked out though his heart shattered with the weight of her dying wish. Angela's hand fell from his cheek as her final breath escaped her lips.

Overwhelmed by loss, Edward's scream reverberated through the crumbling house, a raw manifestation of his sorrow. His magic surged again, reshaping the house's remnants into an unrecognizable form. The trauma overwhelmed him, and as the world faded into darkness, Edward collapsed, unconscious, his final thoughts a whirlwind of pain and loss.

Edward awoke to a changed world; his body felt heavy with grief and his magic subdued but present. The memory of Angela's words lingered in his mind, a guiding light in the shadows of his despair. Though the house was gone and his life forever altered, Edward resolved to honour his mother's final request—to channel his power towards healing rather than destruction even in a world intent on tearing itself apart. Edward fell unconscious.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom of Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 3am

In the dimly lit corridor of the castle, Galahad and Lohengrin sat close together, their sombre silence echoing against the ancient stone walls. Lohengrin's tears left dark stains on Galahad's tunic, each drop a testament to his shattered world.

'I remember a time when me and Loholt were pretending to be knights?' Galahad said softly, his voice a gentle balm to the raw grief between them. Lohengrin looked up, a spark of curiosity flickering through his tear-glazed eyes.

Galahad continued, a wistful smile breaking through his own sorrow. 'We knocked over an armour stand in the training hall, and it clattered to the floor, pieces scattering everywhere. Guinevere was furious at first, but then . . . she helped you pick up every piece. She said that most things in life that break can be mended if only you're willing to invest the time and effort.'

Lohengrin's lips trembled into a sad smile as the memory washed over him. 'She always found a lesson in every mishap. How are we going to carry on this kingdom without her? Why won't she let me heal her?' he murmured, his voice thick with emotion as his hands started to glow with white magic. Galahad smiled softly and said, 'She wanted to see Arthur.'

The door to Guinevere's chamber creaked open, and Loholt emerged, his face a mask of composed grief. He paused, taking a deep breath before facing them. 'She's passed,' he said quietly, the finality of his words striking like a cold wind.

Lohengrin's body stiffened, his grief suddenly a palpable, crushing force. Galahad reached out, his hand gripping Lohengrin's shoulder firmly. 'Did she suffer?' he asked, his voice barely a whisper.

Loholt shook his head slowly. 'No, she was at peace,' he replied, his eyes clouded with unshed tears. Yet his gaze flickered nervously, hiding a deeper turmoil. 'We should prepare the people for the morning. They must learn of our loss.'

As they embraced, a faint green glow caught Lohengrin's eye—the symbol of betrayal fading from where it had been emblazoned on Guinevere's hand. Lohengrin's heart sank as he pieced together her final messages, the truths she tried to convey in her last moments. 'What did she say at the end?' Lohengrin asked, his voice strained, now noticing the uneasy shift in Loholt's demeanour.

Loholt's expression softened, his earlier resolve faltering. 'She told me . . . to keep Camelot united, to mend what has been broken,' he whispered, echoing Guinevere's lifelong lesson. 'And to beware the dragons hidden amongst us.'

The green glow flickering from Loholt's clothing—the unmistakable mark of Guinevere's magic—signalled a dire revelation to Lohengrin. His mind reeled, connecting the lurking shadows of betrayal with Loholt's strained composure. As they turned towards Merlin's spell room, the weight of Guinevere's wisdom and warnings pressed down upon them. Lohengrin felt a new resolve building within him, fuelled by his mother's enduring spirit and the secret betrayals he now needed to confront.

Together, they walked down the torch-lit hall, their steps resonant with the duty and determination that lay ahead. The soft closing of Guinevere's chamber door marked both an end and a beginning as the castle's shadows whispered of change and challenge.

Lohengrin's eyes, however, stayed fixed on Loholt, a mix of sorrow and suspicion brewing as the reality of his mother's last warning unfolded before him.

In King Arthur's bedroom, William stood, his breath caught in his throat and his hand over his mouth as if to trap the words that threatened to spill out. The dreadful plan he had just uncovered reverberated in his mind with horrifying clarity—Loholt was brewing a potion to erase the memory of all those he had slain during the Malazan invasion.

Compelled by the urgency of this revelation, William fled the castle, his journey to Margaret's remote home marked by desperate haste. He passed through the kingdom's green magical shield, which still shimmered faintly in the night, recently battered by a dragon's assault yet holding strong. The path, once familiar, was now twisted under the weight of his dire purpose, each step echoing his pounding heart.

Upon reaching Margaret's cottage, hidden on the outskirts of the shielded area, William hammered on her door with a fervour that split the quiet night. Margaret, who was roused from sleep, swung the door open, her face etched with confusion that swiftly turned to alarm at the sight of him.

'He's planning to make everyone forget the atrocities he committed during the invasion,' William gasped out, the words tumbling in a frantic rush.

Margaret's face hardened, her worst fears confirmed. 'I told you he was a cold-blooded killer,' she whispered, her voice tinged with a mix of vindication and dread.

They stepped into the warmth of her cottage, the night's chill clinging to them. William began to pace, his mind racing. 'We can't let him carry this out, Margaret. It's monstrous.'

Margaret locked eyes with him, her resolve like steel. 'There's only one way to stop him,' she declared, her voice resolute. 'We need to end this, for good.'

A memory surged in William's mind, haunting him—a poignant moment just before the invasion when Margaret's father had entrusted her safety to him. 'Protect my daughter,' he had urged, his tone grave. 'Protect her even if it means leaving Camelot.'

'I promised him I would,' William muttered, his voice thick with emotion.

Margaret vanished into another room and returned with a dark glass vial. 'Merlin gave this to my father for protection,' she explained, holding up the vial with steady hands.

Together, they prepared their grim task. William picked a sword from Margaret's collection that resembled Excalibur, and together, they dipped the sword's grip into the poison, ensuring that any contact by Loholt would be lethal.

'We do this for the kingdom, for its forgotten souls,' Margaret stated, her eyes fierce with determination.

'Let's end this nightmare,' William agreed, his voice a low resolve.

With the poisoned weapon secured, they prepared for William's return to the kingdom. As they did, William felt a pang of guilt for drawing Margaret into this dangerous plot. 'I should be the one to give the sword to Loholt,' he insisted, his voice laden with the weight of his duty and the fear of endangering her further.

Margaret met his gaze, her resolve as hard as the steel they would wield. 'We'll see this through, William,' she assured him, her voice steady despite the uncertainty that lay ahead.

Meanwhile, Galahad moved silently through the shadowed streets of Camelot, his heart heavy with a secret burden. Cloaked in the darkness of the night, he arrived at a large, nondescript wooden building, knocking in a distinctive pattern that echoed softly through the quiet. The door creaked open, revealing Aglovale, a former knight of the Round Table, his face lit by a warm, welcoming smile despite the late hour.

'Come inside,' Aglovale beckoned, his voice a hushed whisper, stepping aside to allow Galahad entry. Once inside, Galahad closed the door gently behind him, his movements deliberate.

'How many now?' he asked, his voice barely above a murmur.

Aglovale's smile widened slightly, a spark of hope flickering in his tired eyes. 'Two more knights joined us today. They've crossed out the Camelot crest on their armour,' he replied, his voice tinged with both pride and sorrow.

Galahad's gaze swept across the room, noting each of the twelve beds, occupied by knights lost in thought or quietly sharpening their swords, preparing for whatever lay ahead. His heart ached for them, for all of them caught in this web of secrecy and rebellion.

'Can we talk somewhere private?' Galahad's tone was urgent, and Aglovale nodded, leading him to a smaller, more secluded room. Once inside, Aglovale shut the door firmly and crossed his arms, the weight of their clandestine meeting pressing down on him.

'What's going on?' Aglovale asked, his brow furrowed in concern.

Galahad paused, ensuring the door was securely closed, before sitting heavily on a small wooden chair. 'Guinevere is dead,' he stated flatly, the words falling like stones in the quiet room.

Aglovale's face fell, his hands rising to cover his mouth as a grief-stricken gasp escaped him. 'How?' his voice was a choked whisper, disbelief and sorrow mingling in his expression.

Galahad's eyes, filled with pain, met Aglovale's. 'Loholt knows the order is fracturing. Too many knights have disappeared,' he continued, his voice steady despite the turmoil inside. 'But I believe tomorrow is the time to act. We start causing chaos, and I'll tell the people that the knights of Camelot abandoned him because of his tyranny.'

Aglovale shook his head, a frown etching deeper into his weathered face. 'The people aren't that easily fooled,' he argued softly.

But Galahad leaned forward, a spark of determination in his eyes. 'The people already despise him. They just need a spark to turn their frustration into action,' he insisted, his hands clenched.

Aglovale stared at Galahad; uncertainty and hope were warring within him. After a long moment, he nodded slowly, resignation etching his features. 'Maybe . . . just maybe.'

Galahad placed a firm hand on Aglovale's shoulder, squeezing gently. 'This is our moment, Aglovale. Everything we've worked for, it's about to pay off. When Loholt tries to declare himself king, we strike, create chaos, target him. It will be pandemonium, but it'll be the catalyst we need.'

Aglovale's nod was slow, his face still shadowed with doubt. 'It sounds right, Galahad. I just . . . can't believe she's really gone,' he murmured, his voice cracking with emotion.

Galahad moved to sit beside his old friend, sharing in the burden of their grim plans. 'I know,' he whispered, his own voice thick with grief.

As they sat together in the dim light of the room, Aglovale leaned on Galahad, struggling to hold back tears. Galahad wrapped an arm around him, offering silent, solid comfort. Together, they braced for the storm they were about to unleash, their hearts heavy with the weight of impending betrayal and the loss of a queen who had been like a mother to many.

Multiverse of Time, Earth Moon, Chrono Shadows Headquarters, Year 4821 21 October, 1 pm

Joshua approached the portal, his gaze momentarily resting on a metal table beside him, where a scroll lay unrolled. His eyes drifted to the left, and there he saw Tom standing just as vividly as the last time they were there together. Tom, his best and only friend—the one person Joshua had trusted in a world that seemed to have forgotten him, was now just a ghost of memories. 'You got this,' Tom's voice echoed in his mind, clear and strong, despite the shadows that had taken him, swallowed whole by the Chrono Shadows on their last mission together.

A single tear trailed down Joshua's cheek as he remembered the bitter end. Tom had either been taken or killed; they never found out which. The agency had turned cold after that, viewing Joshua with suspicion and fear, their eyes always filled with unspoken questions about his loyalty.

He adjusted his medieval armour, fingers tracing the Camelot insignia, feeling the weight of it all—so much heavier without Tom. Picking up the scroll, a woman's voice resonated from the portal, cool and formal yet underscored with urgency, 'You have been specifically chosen for this mission to stop this man from destroying time and space against my better judgment.'

A bittersweet smile tugged at Joshua's lips as he responded softly, 'Well, I completed the last mission, didn't I? Even though it cost us dearly.' His voice carried a mix of defiance and sorrow, the scars of past battles etched deep within him.

The voice continued, relentless and precise, 'Triple tap your watch, and it will bring you back here, ready for your next mission.'

The metal portal flared to life in front of him, glowing red and blue, its hum escalating into a roar. Joshua took a deep breath, his hands trembling slightly as the ground beneath him vibrated. 'It doesn't hurt that much,' he mumbled to himself, trying to convince his racing heart more than anything. The pain from their last travel still haunted him, a sharp, searing memory that lingered uncomfortably in his muscles.

He could almost feel Tom's reassuring presence beside him, pushing him forward. With a heavy heart filled with resolve and the ghost of his friend's encouragement, Joshua closed his eyes and stepped into the portal. The familiar sensation hit him like wax strips being ripped from his skin, the discomfort sharp and intense.

As his heart pounded in his ears, drowning out the roaring portal, his ears popped, and he opened his eyes—alone but carried forward by the memory of Tom, guiding him into the unknown.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom of Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 10 am

As the portal sealed behind him with a shimmer of ethereal light, Joshua found himself standing in an ancient wooden structure. The smell of burning timber hung heavily in the air, a stark reminder of the ongoing chaos. Above him, flames hungrily licked at the rafters, casting eerie shadows that danced across the walls.

He unrolled the scroll, eyeing the figure depicted with a mixture of awe and scepticism. 'This person is supposed to destroy space and time?' he muttered in disbelief, the weight of his task settling heavily on his shoulders.

Suddenly, a woman's scream pierced the smoky air from outside. Instinctively, Joshua rushed out, stepping into the chaos that had engulfed Camelot. The sight that greeted him was overwhelming—buildings crumbled under the assault of dragons soaring overhead, their fiery breath turning stone to ash as terrified citizens fled in all directions. The air was thick with smoke and the cries of the despairing, each sound a blade to Joshua's heart.

Meanwhile, across the kingdom, another scene unfolded as a portal of swirling red and blue light opened above a turbulent body of water. From its depths, Noah, a figure both man and panther, emerged fighting through the churning waves. He swam with desperate strength towards the cave beneath Camelot, his form half-submerged in the cold, biting waves.

Reaching the rocky shore, Noah caught sight of his reflection in the water's shimmering surface. A panther's face stared back at him, its green eyes glowing ominously. He recoiled, startled by his own image—his hands now covered in sleek black fur, claws where his

fingers should be. On one hand, a wedding ring inscribed with the name 'Hope' reflected the faint light, alongside another ring adorned with a glowing red stone.

He glanced at his father's old watch, its screen displaying a countdown, seventy-four hours left. Swiping the watch's surface revealed his exact location: 'Earth, Somerset, Kingdom of Camelot, year 1232, 24 July, 10.02 am.' Another swipe shifted the display: 'Next, Earth, New York, year 4082, 3 July, 2 pm.' Noah's eyes lingered on the countdown, a sense of urgency building within him as distant screams echoed from the cave entrance above.

'I have to help,' he muttered, determination strengthening his voice. Sprinting towards the cliffside of Camelot, Noah extended his right hand and closed his eyes, channelling his newfound magical power. He envisioned stairs rising before him, his eyes glowing a fierce red as the magic surged through his veins. Stone steps materialised, leading him upward towards the heart of the destruction. A small smile played on his lips. 'I could get used to this power,' he whispered, ascending the magically conjured steps into the heart of Camelot's turmoil, ready to confront whatever awaited him.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Lublin, Poland, Year 1939, 27 September, 1.30 pm

Edward lay motionless amidst the rubble of his once beloved home, the eerie silence broken only by the sound of approaching footsteps. Two figures emerged from the shadows, their outlines stark against the debris. The first to step forward was Evan, his face grim as he surveyed the devastation around them.

'He looks so peaceful, unaware,' Evan murmured, his voice soft and faint, echoing amidst the wreckage.

Beside him, moving with a deliberate slowness, was Merlin. His ageless eyes, deep and knowing, fixed on Edward as if weighing his very soul.

'Yes, this is the right Edward,' Merlin said, his tone heavy with meaning. 'Just look at what has unfolded in his home.'

Evan turned, glancing at the shattered remains of the upper story, barely clinging to what was left of the structure. 'It looks like a bomb went off,' he commented, his voice hollow with disbelief.

Merlin gave a small, enigmatic smile. 'In a way, one has,' he replied cryptically.

Merlin approached Edward, kneeling beside him with a gentleness that contrasted sharply with his immense power. He lifted Edward, cradling him with care. Evan, his brow furrowed, watched in uncertainty.

'I don't think this is right,' Evan said, his voice tinged with hesitation. 'Everyone else had a choice to go to your school. This . . . this isn't a choice.'

Merlin's gaze met Evan's, steady and unyielding. 'If we leave him here, he won't live long enough to make a choice,' Merlin replied firmly though not without compassion.

The distant wail of sirens began to pierce the stillness, growing closer. Merlin turned to Evan. “So are you going to open a portal, or should we wait for the soldiers to arrive?”

With a resigned sigh, Evan extended his hands, fingers tracing through the air as he conjured a swirling portal of blue and red magic. It shimmered into existence before them, a doorway to another world. Together they stepped through, carrying Edward between them and leaving behind the shattered remnants of his old life.

Genesis, Merlin’s School, Year 1, 22 November, 9am

As consciousness slowly returned, Edward found himself lying in a stone-cold bed, the room dimly lit by the flickering glow of a single flame hanging from the ceiling. The stone walls felt as oppressive as the silence, and the door remained shut. By the doorway, Merlin stood, his silhouette cast in shadow and his familiar robe still richly hued but worn from time. The once vibrant red scarf he always wore had faded, its colour dulled by time.

Edward’s voice cracked as he struggled to speak, hoarse with confusion and dread. ‘Where’s my mother?’ The words echoed faintly off the walls, hanging heavy in the air.

Merlin turned slowly, his face a mask of sorrow tempered by unshakable resolve. He took a deep breath, preparing to deliver the words that would crush the last of Edward’s hope. ‘I’m sorry for your loss,’ he said softly, each word laced with the weight of finality.

The news hit Edward like a physical blow. Fury flared in his chest, and he staggered to his feet, grief fuelling a surge of raw magic. His eyes blazed with an eerie green light, tendrils of energy sparking from his arms. ‘You’re lying!’ he shouted, his denial shaking the very room. ‘She can’t be dead!’

Merlin moved towards him, calm and measured. He gently placed his hands on Edward’s trembling shoulders and repeated, ‘She’s gone, Edward.’

The magic in the air intensified, swirling around them both, drawn from the depths of Edward’s anguish. Objects in the room lifted off the ground, caught in the tumult of his grief. But as quickly as it had surged, the energy began to fade. Edward’s strength crumbled under the weight of his grief, and he fell to his knees, tears streaming down his face. ‘I was supposed to protect her,’ he sobbed, his voice barely holding together. ‘I made a promise to my father.’

‘There was nothing you could have done,’ Merlin said quietly, his tone gentle but firm, seasoned by the harshness of too many such truths. The room trembled again, the air crackling as several portals snapped open, their shimmering edges cutting through reality itself.

With a heavy heart, Merlin stepped back, extending his palm to reveal a small blue pill. ‘You have a choice, Edward. Take this pill and join the Order of Keepers—gain the knowledge to understand every word ever spoken. Or’—Merlin gestured towards a shimmering portal lined with blue and red light—‘return to a home now filled with ghosts and shattered dreams.’

Edward's eyes darted between the pill and the portal, his mind reeling with the weight of the decision before him. Finally, his voice trembling, he asked, 'Is my mum really gone?'

Merlin nodded solemnly, his gaze unyielding. 'Yes, Edward. She's not coming back.'

With a heavy sigh, Edward took the pill, swallowing it with a mix of dread and reluctant acceptance. As he did, Merlin murmured, 'I'm sorry about this part,' before turning and leaving the room, his presence fading into the shadows.

Almost immediately, Edward felt a strange sensation crawling up his nose. His senses began to warp, the world distorting around him. Frantically, he wiped at his face, panic setting in as his hearing dissolved into a high-pitched ringing. The pain was sudden and overwhelming, and he dropped to the ground, clutching his head. His screams filled the air as confusion and agony tore through him, feeling as though someone was hacking into his brain, overwriting and readjusting all his senses, the world unravelling as the effects of the pill took hold.

After a few agonising moments, Edward's screams finally faded into the thick, suffocating air of the mysterious room. Silence fell like a heavy blanket, smothering the echoes of his pain. His breathing was ragged, his body trembling as he slowly pushed himself up from the cold floor, his mind clouded with confusion.

'Why can I hear better now?' he muttered with a strange mix of awe and fear in his voice. Shaky on his feet, he staggered to the door and pushed it open, only to be met with a sight that defied all logic. Before him stretched an endless black void, a vast canvas dotted with cold, twinkling stars against the infinite darkness.

Peering down, he saw Merlin standing with three others in a clearing, surrounded by a crowd of teenagers. They wore strange, otherworldly outfits—clothing that blended elements of historical armour with fantastical, otherworldly designs. Merlin's voice carried up to Edward, calm and welcoming, 'Everyone, come and join the group.'

Edward's gaze swept over the surreal scene, his mind struggling to grasp what was unfolding before him. On either side of the corridor where he stood, doors like his own appeared, impossibly close and defying any sense of normal architecture. 'How's that possible?' he whispered to himself, his voice barely rising above the soft murmur of the gathering below.

Taking a deep breath to steady himself, Edward descended the stairs and joined the assembly at the front, where Merlin was already speaking. 'Welcome,' Merlin said, addressing the crowd, 'you have chosen to cast aside the constraints of time and space to join my school—a unique school of magic. You will be its first students.'

A voice from the crowd interrupted, the question laced with curiosity. 'Why did you have us take those blue pills?'

Merlin's smile was faint and enigmatic. 'The blue pills you consumed are imbued with time magic. They act as a translator, allowing every spoken word to be understood in your local

language. Think of it as a buffer between your ears and your brain, interpreting sound waves.'

The crowd buzzed with excitement at the revelation. Another student piped up, 'So time magic is blue. What about other types of magic?'

Merlin gestured with a flick of his hand, and the air before him shimmered, transforming into a floating apple. 'Red magic is reality magic,' he said, watching as the crowd marvelled. Beside him, Evan demonstrated time magic, swirling blue light around his watch and reversing its hands.

A woman in white robes, adorned with intricate patterns, raised her hands. Green symbols glowed before her as she spoke. 'Green magic is soul magic,' she declared. On Merlin's other side, a man named Marcus rubbed his palms together, white magic enveloping them as a small plant sprouted from his hand. 'White magic is life magic—the force that binds us,' Marcus explained, his voice steady.

Merlin glanced around at the eager faces, all filled with curiosity and wonder. 'Any more questions?' he asked, knowing that this was only the beginning of a long day filled with eager minds ready to unlock the mysteries of magic.

Standing among them, Edward felt his earlier confusion ebb away, replaced by a growing sense of curiosity and wonder. The pain and grief he had carried now seemed distant, replaced by the thrill of the unknown and the possibilities that lay ahead in this strange new world.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom of Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 7am

As dawn's first light seeped through the gaps between the wood in her cabin, Margaret stirred from a restless sleep. The cool breeze carried faint whispers of the village coming to life. The floor's groan beneath her feet echoed her own weariness as she swung her legs off the bed, the ache of yesterday's labours a persistent reminder.

She cast aside the woollen blankets, the weight of them like the burdens she carried, and she stretched, her muscles tight with resolve. At the window, she pulled back the curtain, revealing the meadows stretching towards Camelot's towering silhouette. The sight wasn't just a view; it was a calling, a reminder of what had to be done.

Today, she wasn't just another villager. Today, she was the daughter of a man wronged, stepping into the shadow of a kingdom to face his killer.

Her tunic and trousers clung to her as she dressed, and her movements were quick and driven. Her hand hovered over the hilt of her father's sword, worn but steadfast. The blade, dulled by time, reflected her own wavering courage. 'We both need sharpening,' she murmured, her fingers brushing its edge.

Outside, the morning air was crisp, filling her lungs like a promise. Passing the familiar anvil and hammer—silent now but brimming with memories of her father's lessons—she picked

up a sharpening block. The rhythm of the blade on stone steadied her thoughts. The sword gleamed sharp and ready when she sheathed it, a spark of determination lighting her weary eyes.

Margaret turned towards Camelot. Each step forward was a step towards justice, the weight of her mission trailing her like a shadow. Today, the girl who had grown up in this quiet cabin would walk into history—a warrior ready to confront her destiny.

In the dim chamber, Loholt awoke to a silence so thick it felt suffocating, his breath catching as if the stillness might crush him. His eyes flicked to the mirror across the room. The image that stared back twisted his stomach—a man consumed by rage and regret. He quickly averted his gaze, but his mother's haunting words echoed in his mind, unrelenting, 'I'm sorry I brought a monster like you into this world.' They clung to him like a shadow, a reminder that even in death, her condemnation lived on.

A flash of fury overtook him. His fist clenched as if to crush the words from existence. Without thinking, he hurled the mirror to the ground, the crash of glass shattering a silence he could no longer endure. The jagged fragments seemed to mock him, scattered like the pieces of his fractured life.

At the foot of his bed lay his clothes, neatly folded, an irritating display of order in a world that felt anything but. Snarling, he snatched them up and dressed with sharp, angry movements, the fabric pulling tight across his shoulders as if it too resisted him.

'Servant!' Loholt's voice thundered against the stone walls, reverberating with impatience. Each passing second without an answer stoked his irritation into a wildfire.

The door creaked open, and William stumbled inside, his face pale with exhaustion. He barely caught his breath before Loholt descended on him, his tone cutting. 'What took you so long? Plotting to rob me, or just wasting time staring at the sunrise?'

William's voice quivered as he bowed deeply. 'My apologies, my king.'

Loholt's gaze bore into him, the weight of his disdain crushing. 'On your knees,' he demanded coldly. 'Kiss my boots and maybe I'll consider forgiving your failure.'

Shame flushed William's cheeks but fear rooted him to the ground. With trembling lips, he obeyed, the cold leather of Loholt's boots tasting of humiliation. Satisfied, Loholt stepped back, his cruel smirk curling.

'Now,' Loholt barked, turning away, 'help me with my armour. Today, I will take my rightful place as king.'

William's hands shook as he fastened the ornate pieces of metal around Loholt's towering frame. Each clink of the armour resonated with dread. He thought of the poisoned sword waiting in the shadows, and the inevitability of what must come.

Loholt strode from the room with purpose, the weight of his new title in his step, blind to the storm brewing around him and the poison poised to rewrite Camelot's fate.

As the heavy doors groaned open, Loholt stormed into the grand chamber, his presence as sharp as the fractured Round Table at its heart. A massive stone now split the table in two, and within it, Excalibur remained trapped—a silent testimony to Camelot's fractured legacy.

Across the room, Galahad and Lohengrin turned, their faces tense, their division as glaring as the table before them. Loholt's thunderous steps echoed as he approached.

'Fetch the false Excalibur,' Loholt snapped at William, who nodded and disappeared down the corridor.

Loholt seated himself at the splintered table, feigning command but unable to mask the crackling tension. 'The time has come,' he declared, his voice brimming with entitlement, 'for me to take my place as king.'

A sharp laugh escaped Galahad, cutting through the silence like a blade. 'King?' he mocked. 'Do you even understand the weight of that crown?'

Lohengrin's voice was low but biting. 'You believe blood alone makes you fit to lead?'

Loholt's frustration boiled over. 'I am the rightful heir! It is my destiny!' he bellowed, slamming his fists against the table.

Galahad stood, his towering frame an unspoken challenge. 'Camelot was built on the will of the people, not the greed of kings. The people have always chosen their ruler.'

Loholt leapt to his feet, his fury spilling over. 'I will lead Camelot into a new era—a grander one! One the people will thank me for!'

The words landed with no conviction. Lohengrin crossed his arms, his contempt plain. 'Your vision of a grand era sounds more like tyranny.'

Before the argument could erupt further, William returned, the false Excalibur in hand holding by the blade. 'Here, my lord,' he said, setting the sword down. The weapon gleamed, but its deceit was as palpable as the tension in the room.

Lohengrin spoke, his tone measured but strained. 'We must stand united when we announce Guinevere's death. The kingdom cannot afford our division.'

Loholt's lips curved into a calculated smile. 'Agreed. A united front, for the people.' His voice dripped with insincerity as he motioned for them to follow him to the castle balcony.

The trio emerged onto the platform overlooking the bustling courtyard. As Loholt stepped forward, his voice thundered over the crowd, commanding their attention. 'People of Camelot, gather around!' Slowly, the courtyard filled with wary faces, their murmurs hushed as they awaited his words.

'I bear heavy news,' Loholt began, his voice solemn. 'Queen Guinevere has passed.' A gasp rippled through the crowd, grief sweeping like a shadow. Some wept openly, their sorrow a testament to the queen's legacy.

Before the crowd could process the loss, Loholt raised a hand for silence. 'With her passing, a new leader must rise. And as the rightful heir, I—'

The words hung in the air as a thunderous roar shattered the moment. Above, a dragon descended, its copper scales gleaming like molten fire. The beast roared again, its cry shaking the very stones beneath their feet.

Panic surged through the crowd as the dragon unleashed its fiery wrath upon Camelot's magical shield. The barrier trembled; cracks were spreading across its surface as the flames hammered relentlessly.

Loholt stood frozen, but Galahad seized control. 'Everyone, take cover!' he commanded, his voice cutting through the chaos. As the people scattered, Galahad turned to Loholt, his tone sharp. 'This is your moment to lead—do something!'

But Loholt's confidence wavered, his vision of kingship shattering like the shield above them.

A deafening crack ripped through the air, silencing the courtyard. All eyes turned skywards as a colossal dragon descended from the stormy clouds, its copper scales shimmering ominously in the fading sunlight. The creature's roar pierced the atmosphere, shaking the very stones of Camelot with its fury.

'The shield will hold!' Loholt bellowed, his voice brimming with desperation rather than conviction. But the dragon unleashed a torrent of fire against the magical barrier, and the once-impenetrable green shield cracked and splintered, the protective magic disintegrating under the relentless assault.

Panic gripped the crowd. Mothers clutched their children, and villagers scattered in every direction. The thundering chaos swallowed Loholt's words as he stood frozen, paralysed by the unfolding disaster.

'Inside! Everyone, take cover!' Galahad's commanding voice cut through the chaos. He shoved past Loholt, his instincts taking over. The crowd surged towards safety, their cries echoing off the stone walls. Meanwhile, Galahad turned to Loholt, Lohengrin, and William. 'Move! We regroup inside!' he ordered.

Once within the castle's thick walls, the group huddled in the war room, their faces pale with the weight of what had transpired. 'How did the shield fail?' Galahad demanded, his voice laced with fury and disbelief.

Lohengrin, thoughtful but grim, responded, 'It's possible the shield was tied to Guinevere's life force. With her gone . . .'

'Can we fix it?' Galahad pressed, his fists clenching.

Lohengrin shook his head. 'Not in time.'

Loholt, unable to contain his frustration, slammed his fist on the table. 'I'll kill the dragon myself! End this once and for all!'

Galahad scoffed, his patience wearing thin. 'You think we haven't tried that? The beast is more powerful than any single sword.'

William cautiously stepped forward, lifting the false Excalibur from the table. 'Perhaps this sword could be of use?' he suggested, his tone careful as he subtly encouraged Loholt towards the poisoned blade.

Loholt waved him off, dismissive. 'That thing? It's just a symbol—not meant for real combat.'

Galahad, resolute, grabbed his own weapon and turned to the door. 'I'm going out there to save whomever I can,' he said, his determination cutting through the despair.

Lohengrin, meanwhile, headed towards Merlin's archives. 'I'll search for a way to restore the shield,' he said, his voice heavy with urgency.

As the two left, Loholt remained behind. Alone in the grand hall, he approached the throne. With a sense of entitlement, he seated himself, his fingers tracing the ornate armrests as his gaze fixed on the fractured table before him. While the kingdom teetered on the brink of ruin, he clung to the throne he believed was his by right, the weight of his delusions casting a shadow darker than the dragon's wings.

Genesis, Merlin's School, Year 1, 22 November, 10.30 am

Edward found himself suddenly seated at a desk in a peculiar classroom, the air thick with unspoken questions. Four other teenagers surrounded him: Florence, sharp-eyed and poised; Hildegard, whose quiet confidence seemed rooted in another century; Luca, bright and irreverent; and finally Charles. Charles was impossible to ignore—a hunched figure with a pallid, pinkish hue to his skin, his snub nose and jowly face giving him the uncanny look of a man-pig hybrid. His small darting eyes carried a nervous energy that set him apart even further.

Before anyone could speak, a woman appeared at the front of the room, a swirl of red magic announcing her presence. She smiled warmly, but there was an intensity in her gaze. 'Hello, everyone. My name is Teresa, and I'll be your guide for the next five years,' she said, her tone chipper yet firm.

Florence's shock was visible. 'Five years!' she muttered. 'I thought this was a year at most.' Teresa's light laugh cut through the tension. 'You're welcome to leave,' she said, and with a wave of her hand, a shimmering portal materialised, its swirling reds and blues tempting with escape.

Florence hesitated, her thoughts clearly torn between the predictable life waiting for her in York, 1857, and the enigmatic promise of this place. Teresa's voice was calm but pointed.

‘Leave now, and you forfeit a chance at greatness.’ Something in those words struck deep. With a breath, Florence returned to her seat, and the portal vanished as if it had never been there.

Teresa’s eyes swept over the room. ‘Anyone else?’ she asked. Charles shifted uncomfortably, his pink face contorting with the weight of unshed tears. His voice cracked as he whispered, ‘I do.’

Teresa approached him; her voice was soft but resolute. ‘Charles, you know you can’t go back.’ With a muffled sob, Charles bolted from the room. Teresa followed after him, pausing only to instruct, ‘Stay put, everyone.’

The remaining students exchanged uneasy glances, their whispered conversations filling the void left by Charles’s sudden departure. Luca broke the tension, leaning towards Edward with a casual, friendly grin. ‘I’m Luca. Nice to meet you.’

Edward, still shaken by the unfamiliar surroundings, took his hand and offered a faint smile. ‘Hi, I’m Edward.’

Settling into his chair, Luca’s gaze swept the room. ‘Looks like we’re all from different times. I’m from New York—year 4082. What about you?’

‘Year 1939,’ Edward replied softly. Florence chimed in, ‘Year 1857,’ and Hildegard added, ‘Thirteen hundreds.’

Luca raised an eyebrow, a teasing smirk playing on his lips. ‘Guess I’m the youngest then.’

Hildegard’s voice was steady but serious. ‘I’m fifteen.’ Florence nodded. ‘Me too. Isn’t that odd?’

Luca turned his chair to face them both, curiosity flickering in his expression. ‘Well, today’s my birthday—I just turned fifteen. Is it the same for you?’

The girls nodded, their movements eerily synchronised. All eyes turned to Edward. Feeling the weight of their stares, he hesitated before answering. ‘No . . . I’m fourteen. I’ll be fifteen in a few days.’

Luca tilted his head, his smile fading into contemplation. ‘Weird. Wonder why your portal opened early?’

Florence’s sharp eyes caught Edward’s pained expression. She softened her voice. ‘Are you OK?’

Edward’s chest tightened, memories of his mother rushing back. Her last smile, the warmth of her hand in his, and the way she shielded him until the very end—those were all still raw like a wound that refused to close. He swallowed hard, blinking back tears, and nodded without speaking.

Before anyone could probe further, Teresa reentered the room, her presence commanding immediate attention. 'Charles won't be joining us for now,' she said calmly.

Edward's gaze followed her, desperate for a distraction, while Florence's curiosity bubbled to the surface. 'Why is Charles so . . . peculiar?'

Luca chuckled, attempting to lighten the mood. 'You mean odd, don't you?'

Teresa's smile was brief, her tone laced with seriousness. 'Charles is an alien, and that's why he looks different.'

Edward frowned, struggling to reconcile her words. 'Why does he have a human name then?'

Teresa's expression softened. 'It's not his real name. It's just the closest translation we have.'

Hildegard, her voice barely above a whisper, asked the question that lingered on all their minds. 'Why can't Charles go home?'

Teresa's gaze darkened, her voice tinged with sorrow. 'Because there's nothing left to go back to. His world was destroyed when we brought him here.'

The room fell into an oppressive silence, each student grappling with the weight of her words. Edward clenched his fists under the desk, a silent war raging within him. His grief was mixed with guilt and anger, an ache that he couldn't shake.

Teresa broke the silence, her voice steady and practical. 'In your first year, you'll study all types of magic. By the end, you'll start to discover where your strengths lie.' She paused, letting her words settle. 'This is the beginning of your journey.'

As the others nodded, a sense of determination filled the room, but Edward remained quiet. The crushing loss of his past clashed against the uncertain promise of his future, leaving him caught between worlds. Yet as he glanced around at the strangers who shared this room, a small part of him began to wonder—what if there was still something left to fight for?

Genesis, Merlin's School, Year 1, 22 November, 1.30 pm

Edward, Luca, and the other students trailed behind Teresa as she led them through the ancient stone corridors to training zone 1. Her heels clicked with authority against the flagstone floor as she announced, 'Your first lesson today will be with Evan. The focus, theory and practice of time magic.'

Anticipation buzzed in the air. When they reached the zone, they found Evan surrounded by a group of students. Swirls of shimmering blue light danced around their hands as they attempted to twist the currents of time.

Luca nudged Edward, his eyes wide with a mixture of excitement and apprehension. 'Do you see that? It's beautiful and terrifying.'

Edward nodded but remained silent, his thoughts flickering like an old film reel to the fragments of his home and family.

Teresa's voice, sharp and commanding, cut through the hum of energy. 'Evan! Stick to the basics. We agreed no advanced techniques on the first day.'

Evan paused, a cheeky grin spreading across his face. 'The best way to learn is to dive in,' he replied though a glint of caution betrayed his confidence.

'That's true,' Teresa conceded, 'but only if we're not risking a collapse of reality.'

Unfazed, Evan turned to the new students. 'Alright, listen up,' he began. 'You'll be spending time with Teresa later to explore soul magic, but for now, let's have some fun with time.' He clapped his hands together, the sound echoing with an almost electric resonance.

'First question,' Evan said, scanning their faces. 'What does TIME stand for in magic theory?'

The students exchanged blank looks.

Evan sighed dramatically. 'Temporal, individual, moments, existing,' he said, the words flowing like an incantation. 'It's the foundation of understanding time manipulation.'

As they settled into the lesson, a mischievous glint returned to Evan's eyes. 'Want to see your past?'

The question hung in the air, charged with forbidden allure. Hildegard's hand shot up, her tone cautious. 'Didn't Teresa say—'

'I won't tell if you won't,' Evan interrupted with a wink. His charm and audacity seemed to melt their hesitation.

Luca was the first to jump in, his grin practically splitting his face. 'Hell yes! Show me some magic!'

Evan gathered them into a circle, his demeanour suddenly serious. 'Picture a window in your mind. Behind that window is a memory. Focus on it. Let it come to life before your eyes.'

Edward hesitated but joined in. Slowly, he closed his eyes, conjuring the image of his childhood home—the smell of freshly cut grass, the warmth of sunlight streaming through the kitchen window, and his mother's laughter. As the memory solidified, he felt the tug of time as though he were being pulled backwards into the moment itself.

When Edward opened his eyes, he stood in his old bedroom. Everything was as it had been—the faded wallpaper, the shelf of dusty books, and the creak of the wooden floorboards. Through the window, he saw his younger self playing in the yard with his father, their laughter ringing out like a melody he hadn't heard in years.

Then he saw her—his mother—stepping through the back door, the sun catching the bracelet on her wrist. He reached for the doorknob, heart pounding with a sudden, impossible hope. *I could save them*, he thought, *I could change everything*.

But as he moved towards the stairs, the room shuddered. Evan materialised in front of him, his expression unreadable. ‘Edward, stop.’

‘I can save her!’ Edward shouted, pushing past him.

‘No, you can’t.’ Evan’s voice was steady, almost regretful, as he grabbed Edward’s arm and pulled him back. The room dissolved, the vibrant colours of the past draining away into a cold grey present. Edward stumbled, landing hard on the training floor.

‘You can’t change what’s already happened,’ Evan said firmly, crouching beside him. ‘That’s the price of time magic—it shows you the truth, but it won’t let you rewrite it.’

Edward’s chest heaved with unshed tears as Evan helped him to his feet. But the weight of reality was too much to bear. He tore away from the group, running blindly through the academy’s corridors.

Luca followed, his footsteps echoing like a drumbeat. When Edward reached his chamber, he slammed the door so hard it reverberated through the walls. Luca arrived moments later, hesitating before sitting outside the door.

‘Edward?’ he called softly, his voice thick with concern.

There was only silence.

Luca leaned against the door, his tone gentle. ‘I know it hurts,’ he said. ‘Losing your home, your family . . . it feels like the world’s been ripped away, leaving nothing but emptiness.’

On the other side of the door, Edward pressed his forehead against the cold wood, his breathing uneven.

Luca continued, quieter now. ‘For what it’s worth, I understand. My home was a little tavern called Sits and Drinks. My mom was terrible at cooking, but somehow, every customer ordered the same burnt chicken tenders. It was chaotic, but it was home.’

Edward let out a small, broken laugh despite himself.

‘It’s the little things, isn’t it?’ Luca said, his own smile tinged with sadness. ‘But, Edward . . . this place, this academy? It’s a chance for something new. We can’t go back, but maybe we can build something worth fighting for.’

The door creaked open, and Edward stepped out, his eyes red-rimmed but resolute. Without a word, he sat beside Luca.

For a moment, they sat in silence, two souls bound by loss and the faint glimmer of hope.

Genesis, Merlin's School, Year 1, 22 December, 9.30 am

Edward felt the crushing impact as the magic blast hurled him through the air. The world blurred around him before he landed hard on the rocky ground, pain searing through his body. Gritting his teeth, he pushed himself to his knees, gasping for air. Across the battlefield, his opponent strode forward with an unsettling calm, his every step deliberate and his expression unreadable yet radiating authority.

Shaking off the daze, Edward rose to his feet, brushing dirt and blood from his torn clothes. The ground began to quake beneath him, small stones lifting and swirling as though caught in the grip of an invisible storm. He closed his eyes. Teresa's voice was echoing in his mind, *Your soul animal is your guide and source. Draw upon its strengths—its instincts. Become it.*

The memory sparked a determination within him. Green energy erupted around Edward, surging through his veins and encasing him in a glowing aura. He felt the familiar warmth of his soul animal—a dragon—awakening within him. With a deep breath, translucent emerald wings burst from his back, their spectral presence radiating power.

His opponent smirked faintly, unperturbed. Rocks rose in a whirling cascade, forming a wall of jagged earth that loomed before Edward. Then without hesitation, the wall surged forward, deadly and unstoppable. Edward crouched low, his wings unfurling in one fluid motion as he leapt skyward. The ground seemed to shrink beneath him as the wings carried him over the incoming barrage with breathtaking ease.

He landed with a forceful grace, skidding to a stop. A fleeting sense of triumph flared in him as he saw the astonishment flicker across his opponent's face. The other youth's expression hardened, his hands igniting with red magic that crackled like fire, raw and furious. He began summoning something far more dangerous.

Edward knew he had no time to waste. Drawing from the lessons he'd practised with Evan, he focused every fibre of his being on the flow of time itself. Blue energy coiled around his hands, its ethereal glow casting a cold light. He thrust his hands forward, the magic streaking towards his opponent like a comet. It struck true, halting the youth in mid-motion. Time itself bent and froze around him.

Edward let out a ragged breath, relief washing over him as he straightened. 'Looks like I win,' he called out, his voice tinged with pride.

But Merlin's voice rang out, sharp and unyielding, 'No.'

Edward turned, confusion etched across his face. 'What? He can't move! How is this not a victory?'

The answer came too late. The ground quaked violently as a second wave of rocks, larger and faster than before, collided with his back. Pain erupted anew as the impact threw him forward, the sharp sting of a fresh wound tracing his temple. Blood trickled down his face as he crumpled to the ground, his vision blurring.

Before Edward could rise, Marcus rushed to his side, the glow of white magic emanating from his hands as he healed the injury with practiced efficiency. Though the pain dulled and his strength returned, humiliation burned hotter than any wound. He struggled to his feet, clenching his fists, frustration and embarrassment threatening to overwhelm him.

Merlin stood beside Edward's now-unfrozen opponent and raised the youth's hand high. 'Victory goes to Aasim,' he declared, his voice resolute.

Edward's heart sank as the words landed like a blow. Aasim, his face apologetic yet cautious, approached and extended a hand. 'Hey, sorry about that hit from behind. I didn't think it would land. We good?'

Edward's chest tightened, anger bubbling just beneath the surface. He barely glanced at Aasim's outstretched hand before turning and storming off, his thoughts a whirlwind of resentment and self-doubt.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 10am

As chaos reigned and flames engulfed the kingdom, Margaret stood amidst the devastation, her eyes wide with both horror and resolve. The dragon swooped down again, its fiery breath turning everything it touched into ashes. People screamed and ran in all directions, some trampling over others in their frantic bid to escape.

Margaret's voice cut through the tumult. 'Get out of the kingdom!' she bellowed, pointing desperately towards the gates. 'Everyone, leave the kingdom! It's not safe anymore!' Her command resonated with the urgency of the situation, and she began to usher people towards the relative safety of the open gates.

Seeing a child stumble and fall, Margaret rushed over, lifting him by the shoulders and steering him towards the gate. She repeated this again and again, helping anyone she could find. Her heart was pounding with a mix of fear and adrenaline.

Margaret's resolve only hardened as the dragon made another devastating pass, scorching the ground near her. She spotted a man frozen in place, staring at a building engulfed in flames. 'You have to run,' she urged, grabbing his arm. The man's eyes were filled with tears as he replied, 'This was my father's place when he passed. I promised him I would look after it.'

Margaret shook her head, her voice firm yet compassionate. 'This is just a thing. Things can be replaced, but people can't. You have to go!' The man hesitated and then nodded, tearing his gaze away from the flames.

She quickly snatched a charred plank from the ruins. 'Here, with this, there will always be a part of the building with you,' she said, thrusting the wood into his hands. With a grateful but heartbroken thank-you, the man turned and fled towards safety.

As Margaret turned to aid the defenceless, her gaze fell upon a man wielding a sword, menacing those too weak to escape. Her fury blazed like wildfire, and with a fierce cry, she

unsheathed her blade and charged. 'Enough!' she shouted, her sword clashing against his. The impact resonated through the chaos. The people she protected scattered like leaves before a gale, seeking refuge from the storm.

Margaret planted their crossed swords into the earth, stepping back to reassess. The knight smirked wickedly. 'Margaret?' he said, recognition flickering in his eyes. Confusion clouded her mind as she hefted her heavy sword above her head, but the knight deftly parried and shoved her back, sending her sprawling. Her weapon was torn from her grasp, and he advanced with measured steps.

Suddenly, an arrow whizzed past the knight's head, striking a charred building beside them. The knight turned, ready to retaliate, but Joshua's second arrow struck true, embedding itself in his marked chest armour. Before the knight could react, Joshua slid between his legs, slashing his hamstring with a dagger. In a fluid motion, he sprang onto the knight's back and drove an arrow into the back of his head, slipping it between the armour plates. Turning to Margaret, he extended his hand. His eyes were searching hers, discerning friend from foe.

Noah ascended the castle walls on the kingdom's side facing the river, conjuring a staircase of crimson from the stone with his red magic. As he vaulted onto the wall, the dragon roared above. Its fiery breath was igniting buildings rather than attacking the fleeing townsfolk.

The door behind him burst open, and knights emerged, a tense silence hanging between them. They stared at Noah, uncertain, until one shouted, 'He destroyed the shield!' Arrows flew as the knights released a volley in his direction. Noah dodged, weaving through the deadly rain. 'What shield? The dragon is the one laying waste to everything! Shoot at him!' he bellowed.

As the arrows flew, Noah looked at his three-fingered hands, realising the extent of his power. His eyes turned a fiery red, and he raised his hands, summoning a stone barrier with his red magic, forcing the knights back inside or off the wall.

With the knights momentarily subdued, Noah's gaze turned skyward to the dragon, his eyes shifting back to green. The dragon's inferno lit the heavens, casting an eerie glow on his determined face as he searched desperately for a means to close the distance to the beast.

As Joshua and Margaret scanned their surroundings, they noticed more knights bearing the crossed-out symbols of Camelot on their armour. Joshua turned to Margaret and asked, 'So they're the enemy?' Still bewildered by why the knight knew her name, Margaret walked over to the fallen knight and pulled off his helmet. Recognising his face, she recoiled, falling to the ground. 'Barnet?' she gasped. Joshua saw Margaret on the ground and asked, 'What's wrong?' Margaret pointed at the knight, her voice trembling. 'That's Barnet. He used to help my father all the time. He was a young knight back then, and now he's dead!' she cried, her voice breaking as she pulled herself away from Joshua.

Joshua walked up to her and knelt beside her, his voice firm yet compassionate. 'Look around. People are getting hurt. People are dying. If we don't stop these knights, more will perish. These knights are no longer your friends or family. The only ones you can trust are yourself and the mission.' He offered his hand, and Margaret, steeling herself, took it and

grabbed her sword. Seeing more knights threatening the townsfolk, she charged at them. Joshua stood back, drawing more arrows and shooting the knights in her path, killing them until one knight noticed Joshua and attacked him.

Joshua deflected the sword strike with his bow, which shattered in the process. He elbowed the knight, breaking part of his helmet and pushing him back. Drawing his sword, Joshua said, 'You'll regret that.' The knight removed his helmet, readying himself for combat.

Joshua heard Margaret's cry for help and saw two knights cornering her. The knight before him seized the opportunity and charged. Joshua blocked the attack, parrying strikes from the left and right. Before the knight could land a blow, Joshua thrust his sword into the knight's chest, piercing through his armour. As the knight's life ebbed away, he gasped, 'What the hell are you?' The knight hung on Joshua's sword, his confusion mirroring Joshua's. Joshua pulled his sword free, blood splattering. As the knight fell to the ground, Joshua looked down at him and said, 'Well, you did well to last as long as you did.' He then pulled a dagger from the fallen knight and ran to help Margaret.

Noah faced the dragon, taking a few steps back as red magic glowed from his hands and his ring. His eyes turned a fiery red, and stone stairs formed in mid-air leading towards the beast. As his eyes returned to green, he took a deep breath and sprinted up the stairs. The dragon noticed and unleashed a torrent of fire, trying to incinerate the steps. Noah leapt, transforming the stairs into the water with his red magic and collided with the dragon in mid-air. They crashed into Camelot's walls, shattering them into pieces. The dragon slowly rose and leapt away while Noah lay unconscious amidst the ruins of the broken stone.

Joshua sprinted towards Margaret, who was now besieged by two knights. One knight, seeing the bodies strewn around them, turned and fled towards the main castle. Reaching Margaret, bloodied but resolute, Joshua urged, 'They're getting away. Come on!' Horrified by the slaughter, Margaret briefly wondered if Joshua might be capable of killing Loholt. Together, they raced towards the main castle, witnessing Noah and the dragon clashing on the walls.

Inside the castle, knights hurriedly erased their crossed-out symbols and found Loholt seated in the king's chair within the grand hall. 'Why are you here?' Loholt demanded. 'We're here to protect you!' one knight quickly responded. Loholt smiled. 'Good, I was wondering when my guards would arrive. Stand over here,' he commanded. The knights complied.

Joshua and Margaret burst into the grand hall. Covered in blood, Joshua asked, 'And who are you supposed to be?' Loholt, eyes narrowing at Joshua, replied, 'I'm the king! Who the hell are you?' Margaret, standing resolutely behind Joshua, declared, 'He's a monster.' Joshua sheathed his sword, eyeing the two knights flanking Loholt. Just then, the doors began to open.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 10.40 am

Galahad strode into the armoury, his eyes scanning the dimly lit room until they settled on Aglovale, waiting in the shadows. 'The knights are doing a fine job creating chaos,' Aglovale remarked, placing his hands on Galahad's shoulders.

'Good,' Galahad replied with a smile, locking eyes with him. 'We want to frighten the people, not slaughter them.'

Aglovale's gaze darkened as he asked, 'Why don't we just kill Loholt? It feels like you're making this more complicated than it needs to be.'

Galahad's expression softened as he gently placed his hand on Aglovale's face. Aglovale closed his eyes, leaning into the touch. 'If we kill Loholt in cold blood, the people will never trust whoever takes the throne next,' Galahad explained, his voice steady.

Aglovale with eyes still closed, murmured, 'Then why don't we just leave? Run away? We don't owe this kingdom anything.'

Galahad met his gaze, searching for understanding. 'It's not about the kingdom. It's about power. If Loholt gains that power unchecked, the danger he could unleash is unimaginable.'

For a brief moment, the chaos outside seemed to fade, replaced by a fragile peace between them. 'I need to show the people I'm one of them,' Galahad said, breaking the silence. He turned to leave but paused at the door. 'I've gambled two years of my life on this plan, lost so much because I believe in you—and your vision. Don't forget that when you seize power.'

'I won't,' Galahad replied, meeting Aglovale's eyes one last time before stepping into the chaos outside.

The scene he walked into was grisly: blood stained the streets, and knights lay lifeless, their chests marked with the crossed-out Camelot symbol. His heart sank as he spotted his apprentice among the dead. Dropping to his knees, grief consumed him as he realised their deaths were the consequence of his actions. He picked up his apprentice's bloodied sword, his hands trembling as he noticed the name of the apprentice's wife carved into the hilt.

Wiping away his tears, Galahad stood, the weight of guilt pressing heavily on his chest. As he rose, the townspeople began to return, cautiously emerging from their hiding places. Seeing him with the bloody sword in hand, standing among the fallen rogue knights, they began to applaud.

The sound of applause caught Galahad off guard. Confused, he sheathed the sword, his voice quiet as he muttered, 'I was only doing my duty.'

As he scanned the faces of the cheering crowd, the weight of his guilt grew unbearable. Then in the distance, he saw Camelot knights pouring out of the castle, celebrating. The dragon was gone, and most of the rogue knights lay dead.

Amidst the rubble, Galahad's gaze fell on Panther Noah, unconscious and battered. Without hesitation, he ordered the knights to drag Noah to the grand hall. Inside, Margaret stood behind Joshua, her eyes darting between him and Loholt, who stood flanked by two guards. Joshua, sensing the impending confrontation, stepped forward, his gaze locked on Loholt.

Galahad stormed in with the knights hauling Noah's limp body into the centre of the room. 'The knights tell me he's a wizard. He may be the reason the shield failed,' Galahad declared, casting a suspicious look towards the panther man. Margaret and the guards gasped at the sight of Noah while Joshua and Loholt exchanged glances, almost recognising him.

Without a moment's pause, Loholt grabbed William's poisoned Excalibur, unsheathing it with deadly intent. He advanced towards Noah, ready to strike. Sensing the danger, William slipped quietly out of the room though he lingered in the castle, unwilling to abandon Margaret.

As Loholt raised the sword high, Lohengrin burst into the hall, shouting, 'Stop!' His cry jolted Noah awake just as Loholt's hand began to turn black from the sword's poison. With a pained scream, Loholt dropped the sword, clutching his hand in agony.

'Do something!' Galahad shouted, turning to Lohengrin, panic rising in his voice.

'I don't know how to fix this,' Lohengrin admitted, dropping the book he had been holding.

Margaret's voice cut through the confusion, filled with fear and anger. "'Stop! He's a monster!'

Lohengrin and Galahad froze, their attention snapping to her. Meanwhile, Noah, his eyes glowing white, reached out with hands radiating white magic. He grasped Loholt's poisoned hands, and slowly, the blackened skin returned to normal as Noah drew the poison out. The deadly substance shifted and morphed in Noah's hands, transforming into a flower as his eyes returned to their natural green glow.

'Being a king isn't about the power to control others. It's about what you can build with them,' Noah said softly to Loholt, his words cutting through the tension.

Frantic and humiliated, Loholt stood abruptly and barked, 'Arrest them!' The guards seized Noah, who offered no resistance. Margaret, in a panic, attempted to flee, but Joshua calmly followed as they were both dragged towards the prison cells, carved by Merlin deep below the castle.

Galahad, Lohengrin, and Loholt remained in the grand hall, surrounded by guards. Loholt, still fuming, ordered the guards to leave. Once alone, Lohengrin turned to Galahad, his voice low. 'Where did you find the panther man?'

'In the rubble, near the dragon,' Galahad replied.

Loholt glanced around the room, searching for William, but found no trace of him. With a frustrated sigh, he sank back into the king's chair and turned his attention to Lohengrin. 'So where are you with fixing the shield?'

Lohengrin retrieved his fallen book, opened it, and read aloud, 'The shield of Camelot will never falter as long as the true leader is ruling the kingdom.' He closed the book and fixed his gaze on Loholt.

Galahad frowned, confused. 'What does that mean?'

Loholt strode towards Lohengrin, snatching the book from his hands and reading the passage himself. His face darkened as he muttered, 'Well, I haven't been announced as the new king. That's why the shield isn't working.'

Lohengrin and Galahad exchanged a glance, suspicion flickering between them as the weight of the revelation settled.

Galahad, his voice dripping with sarcasm, said, 'Well, Great King, the dragon's burned down half the kingdom. We need shelter for the people.'

Before Loholt could react, Lohengrin interjected, 'We could set up cloth shelters—or we could ask Noah—'

He paused, looking to Galahad. 'You said his name is Noah?'

'Yes, Noah,' Galahad confirmed.

Lohengrin continued, 'He's powerful enough to restore most of the kingdom before nightfall. And considering he just saved your life, I'm sure he'd be willing to help.'

Loholt's face flushed crimson as he shouted, 'No, not Noah! His appearance here lines up with one of Merlin's prophecies. I believe it says, "As a man and monster appear, they will come for their prize. This will show the true monsters inside this realm as Camelot teeters on the brink of destruction or rebirth." We're better off going with the cloth.'

Galahad, unfazed, suggested, 'Or you could let the people inside the castle, like in the old days.'

Loholt gave a bitter smile. 'And let assassins get closer to me? They've already made one attempt on my life. I'm not giving them another chance.'

Meanwhile, in the dungeon, Noah was shoved into a separate cell from Joshua and Margaret. The guards confiscated Joshua and Margaret's weapons but left Noah's watch and rings untouched. He surveyed his cold, dim cell, feeling the weight of isolation pressing in. Margaret stepped closer to the wall that divided them, her voice cutting through the silence. 'Why the hell did you save him? He's a monster!' she shouted, her voice trembling with anger and pain. Nearby Joshua stretched his arm through the barred door, still trying to reclaim his confiscated weapons.

Noah, frustrated, turned towards Margaret, ready to defend his actions, but his gaze fell on Joshua standing behind her. His heart leapt. 'Joshua?' he called out, his voice tinged with hope and desperation.

Joshua, confused, approached the bars. 'How the hell do you know my name?'

Noah stepped back, his pulse quickening. 'Joshua, it's me—Noah!' His voice wavered, hoping for a flicker of recognition, for someone to see beyond the monstrous form he had become and for someone he once knew.

Margaret, still bewildered, looked between them. 'You know this panther man?'

Joshua's eyes narrowed in suspicion. He remembered the face on the scroll—the one who would destroy space and time. *This is the one I'm here to kill*, he thought. His voice was cold as he replied, 'I've never seen this thing in person before. Trust me, I'd remember.'

Noah locked eyes with Joshua, searching for any sign of familiarity. 'You really don't know who I am, do you?'

Joshua leaned closer, his voice low and dangerous. 'Why the hell would I lie?'

Noah stared at his hands, the realisation sinking in—he was truly alone. No one was coming to help him. A bittersweet smile crept across his lips. 'I'm at the beginning then.'

Joshua turned away, frustration boiling inside him as he returned to trying to reach his weapons. But Noah's voice broke through his focus. 'I'm the next face.'

Joshua froze. The weight of Noah's words settled on him. He longed to complete his mission, to return to the Chrono Shadows, the only world he had ever known. But something tugged at him—curiosity and doubt. Slowly, he turned back to Noah. 'What are you talking about?'

Noah's voice was calm and steady but full of sorrow. 'The face on the scroll. That's me. I'm your next target.'

Joshua stepped up to the bars, perplexed by Noah's calm acceptance, especially given the gravity of being hunted by one of the deadliest secret organisations in existence. 'How do you know that?'

Noah moved closer, his eyes filled with an earnest plea. 'Because I know who you work for. I know what they're like. Trust me, they're not sending you on missions to save the world—they're selling you to the highest bidder.'

Joshua's breath caught, disbelief flashing across his face. 'You're lying.'

Noah leaned in, his voice dropping to a whisper, 'Think about the mission with Tom. What happened after you assassinated that royal? A new group swooped in and took control. They weren't interested in justice.'

Joshua's face contorted with emotion as tears welled in his eyes. He gripped the bars tightly, his voice a broken whisper, 'How do you know that name?'

Noah's sad smile returned. 'Because I know everything about you. I've seen your past—and your future. You've felt it, haven't you? Something's not right with the Chrono Shadows. I just need you to trust me.'

As Joshua stood there, torn between his mission and the growing doubt gnawing at him, Margaret cut through the tension, her voice sharp. 'You still haven't told me why you saved Loholt!'

Noah turned to Margaret, his gaze softening. 'Because he hasn't finished his part in all this. Killing someone for revenge destroys the one who takes the life as much as the one who dies. You know that. That's why you're trying to make someone else do it. I know your future—you'll get your chance to decide what to do. Trust me.'

Just then, the jail doors creaked open, and William entered, keys in hand and a broad smile on his face. 'You didn't think I'd leave you here!' he announced. He unlocked Joshua and Margaret's cell. Margaret leapt at him, throwing her arms around his neck. 'Thank you! I knew you'd come,' she exclaimed, kissing him on the cheek.

Noah remained in his cell, watching the scene unfold. As William approached Noah's door, ready to free him as well, Margaret stopped him. 'He's the reason Loholt is still alive,' she said sharply.

Joshua retrieved his weapons as William turned to Noah. 'I had him! Who made you the judge of who lives and dies?' William demanded, frustration flashing in his eyes.

Noah stepped closer to the bars, meeting William's gaze calmly. 'I could ask you the same thing.'

Annoyed, William turned and walked out of the jail with Margaret. Joshua followed, but as he did, Noah called after him, 'Joshua.'

Joshua paused, his back still to Noah.

'Don't forget who you really are,' Noah said, his voice carrying a weight that made Joshua hesitate. Without a word, Joshua continued out of the jail, leaving Noah behind.

Noah sank down in the middle of his cell, closing his eyes and trying to find a moment of peace amidst the chaos.

He soon drifted off into sleep and awoke in a completely different place—a modern bedroom. Disoriented, Noah pulled the sheet off and walked to the window. His reflection in the glass

caught his eye—he was human again. His hands, all his fingers intact, were familiar yet strange after so long in his altered form. But outside, green souls drifted past the house, and soon he found himself standing in a vast, green void.

Then he heard it—Hope's voice. 'Hello, is there anyone there?'

Noah's heart raced as he rushed out of the room, finding himself in a hallway. He passed a bathroom, a teenager's room, and a child's room and then saw a staircase. Across the house, he heard the voice again, 'Hello? Anyone here?' Noah hurried towards the sound, finding himself by the front door—a bright red door.

He smiled. 'We always wanted a red front door,' he murmured.

Turning around, he saw her. Hope, standing by the kitchen window, was looking out at the green void beyond. 'Hope!' he cried, running to her with open arms. She turned, her face lighting up as Noah lifted her, spinning her around before, and pulling her into a tight embrace.

Setting her down gently, Noah asked, 'Are you OK?'

Hope smiled, playfully tapping his shoulder. 'Noah, I'm always OK when I'm with you.'

They both glanced around, taking in the strange yet familiar surroundings. 'Do you know where we are?' Noah asked, suspicion creeping into his voice.

'No, no idea,' Hope replied with a smile, though something seemed off to Noah.

'Are you sure you're OK? You seem . . . different,' he said, searching her face.

Hope placed her hands on his face, her eyes soft. 'I don't remember anything before this,' she admitted, her voice tinged with uncertainty.

Noah picked up a nearby picture frame, but the figures in it were blurred, indistinct. 'This place, it's like our dream home, the one we always talked about, right down to the red door. But look, these pictures. They're all fading. I don't think this ever happened. Between my curse and everything I did to get back to you . . . we never got here. And if we did, it wouldn't be this perfect.'

Hope stepped closer, her expression thoughtful. 'So you remember something outside this place?'

Noah nodded, a smile tugging at the corners of his mouth. 'Yeah, I do.' But before he could say more, he felt the world shift, and his body collapsed as everything faded.

He awoke with a jolt, back in his cold cell. His vision blurred, but he could just make out a figure standing over him. The man's voice was urgent.

'I need your help,' the stranger said.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 2.20 am

As dusk settled over Camelot, the sky tinged with hues of red and gold, Galahad and Lohengrin worked among the people, lifting the shattered remains of their once-proud homes. The stench of charred wood lingered in the air as Lohengrin moved from one villager to another, his hands glowing softly with healing magic as he tended to the burns that marred their skin. Nearby, Galahad hauled blackened beams into a pile, his muscles straining as the villagers quietly aided him.

Lohengrin, wiping sweat from his brow, glanced towards Galahad and said, 'We should think about putting up the cloth shelters before night falls.'

Galahad looked up, the sun sinking below the horizon, casting long shadows over the ruined kingdom. He nodded. 'You're right,' he replied, setting down the last of the timber. Without wasting time, he made his way towards the castle to gather what cloth they had left for makeshift tents.

As he walked through the dimming streets, his path crossed with Aglovale, who stepped from the shadows, a sly smile playing on his lips. 'What are you doing here?' Galahad asked, his tone edged with suspicion.

Aglovale's smile broadened. 'Just fetching some food from a friend in the kitchens,' he said casually. 'I'm moving the men I have left to the ruins outside the kingdom. Thought I'd stock up before we leave, is that alright?'

Galahad studied him for a moment, his eyes narrowing but nodded. 'Do what you must. I'll meet you there when I'm done here.'

Aglovale's smile didn't falter as he reached for one of the bundles of cloth Galahad was gathering. 'Thank you, o great future king,' he said, mockery lacing his voice as he hefted the bundle over his shoulder.

Without another word, Aglovale disappeared, slipping through a narrow crack in the wall, vanishing into the night.

Galahad watched him go before turning back to his task. With the cloth in hand, he returned to Lohengrin and the people, working swiftly to set up shelters, all the while keeping a wary eye on the shadows. Loholt remained unseen, his absence as heavy as the smoke still hanging in the air.

By the time they finished, the night had fully descended, and the village was quiet save for the crackle of dying embers and the murmur of exhausted voices. Galahad stood with Lohengrin, looking over what remained of Camelot. They both knew the true battle was yet to come.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 4.40 am

Galahad strode into the throne room, his eyes immediately drawn to Loholt, seated smugly upon the throne and surrounded by the shattered remnants of the once-great Round Table. At the centre, Excalibur remained embedded in stone, a fractured symbol of power and the kingdom's broken unity. The tension in the air was thick, but Galahad's voice remained steady. 'Why did you summon me?'

Loholt rose from his seat, a predatory smile playing on his lips as he began to circle the broken table, his gaze never leaving Galahad. 'Do you know the easiest way to unite people?' he asked, his tone casual but dripping with menace. 'You give them a common enemy.'

Galahad frowned, the meaning of Loholt's words settling uneasily in his mind. 'So you're saying people come together through shared hatred?'

Loholt's grin widened as he closed the distance between them. He placed a hand on Galahad's shoulder, leaning in and his voice dropping to a sinister whisper, 'I know you're plotting against me. I saw you in the armoury with that man, planning your little coup.'

Galahad's heart pounded, his hand instinctively tightening around the hilt of his sword. His pulse roared in his ears like the sound of war drums preparing for battle. Loholt leaned closer, his voice a venomous hiss, 'I could have you executed right here and now. But where's the fun in that? Wouldn't it be more . . . entertaining to settle this with a duel? Tomorrow.'

Leaning back, Loholt kept his hands on Galahad's shoulders, relishing the shock that flickered across his rival's face. 'See you tomorrow, enemy,' he sneered, his cold laughter echoing through the throne room as he turned his back and walked away.

Galahad stood frozen, his grip on the sword slackening. As Loholt's laughter faded into the distance, the weight of the moment crashed down on him. His knees buckled, and he fell to the ground, gasping for air. Years of careful planning, strategy, and hope, unravelled in a single devastating moment.

Galahad struggled to rise, his knees weak beneath him, but he forced himself to stand. His breath came in shallow bursts as he left the throne room, the weight of Loholt's words still heavy on his shoulders. As he walked out of the kingdom, every step felt like a leaden echo, his heartbeat pounding relentlessly in his ears. He cast glances over his shoulder with each step, half-expecting to see Loholt's men following him. But no one came.

Once he was clear of the castle walls, Galahad's pace quickened as he made his way towards Aglovale's camp. When he finally arrived, he saw only three knights standing with Aglovale around a dying fire. His heart sank further at the sight. 'God . . . there's only three of you,' he muttered, his voice tinged with despair.

Aglovale stood up quickly, his keen eyes narrowing as he took in the worry etched on Galahad's face. He stepped forward, gripping Galahad's arm. 'What's wrong?' he asked, his voice low but steady.

Galahad swallowed hard, his fear bubbling to the surface. 'I'm set to duel Loholt tomorrow. I . . . I don't think I can beat him. He's stronger, more ruthless. And if I lose . . .' His voice trailed off, the weight of the kingdom's fate bearing down on him.

Aglovale's expression hardened. He glanced around at the few knights who remained. The flickering firelight cast long shadows but determination flickered in his eyes. 'I've got an idea,' Aglovale said, his tone firm, a plan already forming in his mind.

Galahad looked at him, hope mingled with desperation. 'What are you thinking?'

Aglovale gave a grim smile, leaning in closer. 'Loholt may be stronger, but we won't fight him on his terms. Tomorrow, we level the playing field. And when it's over, the people won't see a tyrant sitting on the throne. They'll see their true king.'

As William, Margaret, and Joshua walked briskly down the dim hallways from the jail, the tension between them was almost suffocating. Margaret moved towards the exit, but William veered off in the direction of Loholt's chambers. He glanced back at her, his expression resolute. 'I'm not leaving here until I know Loholt is dead,' he declared, his voice sharp with purpose.

Margaret stopped, turning to face him. Her eyes held a mix of fear and hope. 'Why don't we just leave?' she pleaded, her voice softer now, almost desperate.

William's face hardened, his jaw set. 'He knows I passed him that sword. He'll hunt me down. I can't hide here in this kingdom.'

'There are other kingdoms,' Joshua chimed in. 'You could disappear. Start fresh.'

Margaret's hope flickered again, and she turned back to William, her voice more insistent. 'Let's just go, William. Please.'

For a moment, William hesitated, torn between his vow to Margaret's father and his instinct to protect her. He glanced between Joshua and Margaret, the weight of his decision heavy in the air. Finally, he spoke, his tone firm. 'You two go. I'm not leaving until Loholt is dead.'

Margaret's eyes flashed with determination. 'I'm not leaving you behind. You're the only family I have left—you're like a brother to me.'

Her words struck William deeply, a pang of guilt and love twisting in his chest. He saw the worry etched in her face and sighed, relenting slightly. 'I know a place where you can hide.'

He led them stealthily through the castle's labyrinthine corridors to its deepest level. They paused, hiding behind a pillar as Lohengrin passed by, oblivious to their presence. Once the

way was clear, William guided them to a concealed wall, pressing a hidden stone. Slowly, the wall shifted and slid open, revealing Merlin's secret prophecy chamber.

Margaret stared in awe at the sight. 'How do you even know about this?'

Joshua stepped into the room, his eyes wide as he took in the ancient prophecies lining the walls. Margaret turned and embraced William tightly, her voice thick with emotion. 'Be careful.'

'I will,' William replied, his voice low but steady.

As Margaret entered the hidden room, the stone wall began to close. William locked eyes with Joshua one last time. 'Protect her,' he said, his words carrying the weight of a final request.

Joshua nodded solemnly. 'I will.'

The wall sealed shut, leaving William alone in the silence of the empty corridor. He took a deep breath, steeling himself for what lay ahead. 'Now . . . how am I going to kill Loholt?' he muttered, his resolve hardening like iron in his chest.

Genesis, Merlin's School, Year 2, 12 January, 10.30 pm

Edward's room had transformed into a semblance of a library, where the ancient mingled with the modern. He was seated at his desk, engrossed in a tome called 死の魔法の書—*The Book of Death Magic*. Murmuring to himself, he pondered the dark arts within its pages. 'To wield this magic,' he thought aloud, 'one must harness the dead, using their body, their soul, their very life as fuel for one's power—a power that binds to the soul eternally.'

With a sad determination, Edward reached for the plant beside him, intending to use it as a conduit for his spell. He pulled his mother's bracelet off his wrist, intending to use it to connect to her, and placed it next to the plant. Closing his eyes, he concentrated intensely on his late mother. As his focus intensified, the plant's vitality began to ebb, its colour draining to an ashen grey before disintegrating into dust.

Suddenly, a familiar voice pierced the silence. 'Where am I?' it asked, soft and bewildered.

'Mum?' Edward gasped, his heart pounding as tears fell from his face.

'Edward, is that you? My baby boy?' the voice responded.

Tears streaked down Edward's cheeks as he whispered, 'Yes, it's me, Mum.'

Before he could revel in the moment, the door to his room burst open. Merlin stormed in, his face contorted with concern and anger. 'What the hell are you doing?' he bellowed.

Edward stood defiantly, the book still open on his desk. 'So you lied about there only being four types of magic,' he accused his voice a mix of betrayal and retribution.

Merlin's eyes darted to the book and then to the remains of the plant. 'Don't tell me you're experimenting with death magic?' he demanded, his tone dangerously calm.

'So what if I am?' Edward retorted, his defiance swelling.

With a gesture of frustration and command, Merlin transformed the book into a blooming flower, setting it gently on the desk. 'The balance of life and death must not be tampered with without grave cost. What spell did you cast?'

Edward stepped back, his earlier confidence faltering. 'A spell . . . to speak with my mother.'

Merlin's face reddened with a mixture of anger and sorrow. He took a deep breath and paced the room. 'You foolish boy, jumping straight into one of the darkest spells. Did it work?'

'Yes,' Edward admitted softly.

Merlin paused, his expression softening. 'I'm sorry for what comes next, but you cannot remain here.' He raised his hand, and white magic swirled around, sprouting vines that wrapped around Edward's arms, binding him.

Edward cried out, 'How was I supposed to know?'

Merlin's hands glowed with a fierce red aura as he prepared another spell. 'The gift of understanding every word spoken is now taken from you.'

Edward felt a searing pain as if something was being torn from his mind. He screamed, agony overwhelming his senses.

Outside, Luca approached the room, alarmed by the noise. 'What are you doing to him?' he shouted just as Merlin closed the door with a swift motion of his wrist, muffling the sounds within.

Inside, Edward felt his very magic being stripped away, layer by layer, his pleas for mercy drowned out by his screams. Finally, Merlin ceased, the room falling silent except for the heavy breaths of both mage and apprentice.

Merlin spoke solemnly, 'For breaking the balance of life and death, you are cursed to walk this world as the demon within you.' He then summoned a portal with a wave of his hand, pushing Edward through it with a burst of blue and red magical energy.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1228, 12 July, 1am

Edward landed in a forest, his body undergoing terrifying transformations. Scales emerged, wings sprouted from his back, and claws replaced his fingers. Overcome by panic, he screamed for help, but the transformation rendered him monstrous.

A woman approached, offering assistance, but her words soon became unintelligible. Edward, now more beast than man, roared, 'Run!' just as flames erupted from his mouth,

setting the surrounding area ablaze. The forest around him lit up with fire, and he saw every face around him turn from helpful to fearful. They began throwing things at him, and one knight prepared to attack. As Edward looked at their faces, knowing he was no longer wanted, he started to cry, thinking, *All I wanted was one more conversation with my mother.*

Terrified and in pain, Edward fled towards Camelot, hoping to find Merlin and some way to reverse his cursed fate.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 25 July, 9.10 am

As the dawn of the duel approached, Loholt entered his chamber, his thoughts a tumultuous blend of anticipation and nerves. He paced the floor, whispering, 'Loholt, you're the best. You can't be defeated. You are the greatest warrior ever.' Each word was a hammer strike, forging his resolve for the morrow's clash against Galahad.

Just then, the door creaked slowly closed behind him, casting a long shadow that crept across the floor. Loholt spun around, his heart pounding as William emerged from the shadows. His sword was glinting ominously in the dim light.

Without warning, William lunged, his blade sweeping towards Loholt. Reflexively, Loholt raised his hand, catching the sword mid-swing. Blood dripped from his palm onto the cold steel. 'I think you grabbed a show sword,' Loholt grimaced, seizing the moment to disarm William with a swift strike to the head.

As William staggered backwards, Loholt advanced, fury and adrenaline surging through his veins. He pinned William against the wall, his hands transforming into instruments of wrath, delivering blow after relentless blow. Each punch splattered more blood, painting a grim portrait of his resolve.

Exhausted, Loholt finally let William slump to the floor, gasping for breath. Through bloodied lips, William coughed out a question, 'Why did you kill your mother?'

Loholt's fury paused, his breathing heavy in the charged air. He walked over to his sword. His voice was low and haunted as he said, 'She discovered my secret—the deeds I forced upon Lohengrin's family, the souls I trapped within Excalibur's blade. It was an accident initially, but one does not simply forsake such power.'

Holding the sword aloft, Loholt noticed William's laughter—a broken, mocking sound. 'What are you laughing about?' he demanded, irritation lacing his voice.

'Even your mother despised you,' William gasped between chuckles.

With a cold, hard stare, Loholt brought down the sword, forever silencing William's laughter. He stood back, breath ragged, and called, 'Guards!' As distant footsteps responded to his summons, his voice echoed off the stone walls.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 24 July, 9.10 pm

As the charred remnants of the building loomed around him, Galahad entered, the smell of smoke still clinging to the air. Inside, Aglovale awaited, his posture rigid with anticipation. They embraced briefly—a rare moment of vulnerability between warriors.

‘So the plan has changed,’ Galahad declared, his voice echoing through the hollow chamber.

Aglovale stepped back, confusion and concern etched across his features. ‘Changed how?’ he asked, gripping Galahad’s hands for a moment before letting go.

Galahad withdrew his hands, his eyes searching Aglovale’s. ‘I don’t know how to say this,’ he began, his words heavy.

‘Just spit it out,’ Aglovale urged, his patience thinning.

‘It’s not about sowing chaos anymore.’ Galahad turned, facing the remnants of the round table scattered in ashes around them. ‘It’s about precision, striking at the heart.’

‘So what was the point of me abandoning the order, my life, everything?’ Aglovale’s voice rose in frustration.

‘All we need is to weaken Loholt.’ Galahad continued, his plan unfolding with each word. ‘Not with poison meant to kill but to slow him. Tomorrow, when I fight him to the death, he needs to be less than himself.’

Aglovale’s eyes widened in disbelief. ‘That won’t work. Remember the law of balance—if a king falls by unnatural means, the cost is high, and another life is always claimed.’

Galahad met his gaze squarely. ‘This isn’t about death, but incapacitation. I didn’t choose this duel, but it’s the only way.’

Understanding dawned on Aglovale, and he placed a hand on Galahad’s shoulder, his earlier frustration melting into a resolved grimace. ‘Consider it done,’ he affirmed, a new resolve steeling his voice.

The two shared a look of mutual respect forged in the fires of countless battles and shared secrets. As Aglovale turned to leave, he paused at the doorway, looking back at Galahad, who was now staring into the embers of a still-smouldering timber.

‘May our next meeting be under brighter skies,’ Aglovale said softly and then disappeared into the night, leaving Galahad alone with his thoughts and the ghosts of the past that danced in the flickering shadows.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 25 July, 3.10 am

Joshua leafed through the ancient texts of Merlin’s prophecies, the room pulsing with the weight of secrets untold. Margaret paced restlessly, her movements sharp and jittery as she

awaited William's return. Her nerves were frayed, and she barely registered the content of Joshua's murmur until his words suddenly pierced her distraction.

'Did you know that supposedly Arthur and Guinevere had two children?' Joshua remarked, his eyes not leaving the page.

Margaret halted, her expression twisting with confusion and disbelief. 'No, they didn't. They only ever had one true heir, and that was Loholt. Guinevere might have cared for many, but only one was of her blood.'

Joshua chuckled. An eyebrow raised in challenge as he held up the parchment. 'Well, not according to this.'

Intrigued despite herself, Margaret strode over, her hands extended. Taking the document, she read aloud, her voice gaining strength as she uncovered words that seemed to rewrite history itself. 'In the realm of Camelot, the fates of the first monarch's children unfold in a dangerous dance of destiny and destruction. Bound together, their lives form a tapestry that will lead the kingdom to its salvation or its ruin. Should they separate, one will save Camelot, and the other will destroy it.'

As the prophecy's implications sank in, a solitary tear from Margaret fell onto the ancient paper, revealing further secrets hidden within the ink. 'If you are reading this, it means you are one of the children of the first monarch, and your choices will save Camelot or destroy it,' she said, her voice whispering awe and fear.

Margaret's hands trembled, the paper nearly slipping from her grasp. Turning to Joshua, her eyes wide with a dawning realisation, she whispered, 'What does this mean?'

Joshua's gaze was steady, his voice soft yet confident. 'I think you know. It's revealing a truth long buried.'

Margaret's resolve crumbled as she sank to her knees, the prophecy fluttering beside her. 'My brother,' she gasped, the truth hitting her with the force of a storm, 'he killed my stepfather.'

Joshua knelt beside her, his arms encircling her in a comforting embrace as the weight of their discovery settled heavily upon them. The room was filled with the echoes of a past rewritten and an uncertain future.

Multiverse of Time, Earth, Somerset, Kingdom Camelot, Year 1232, 25 July, 3am

The digits on Noah's watch blinked 57:10 as seventeen hours passed. The prison door creaked open, revealing Lohengrin, who entered with a solemn stride, clutching a dusty tome. Noah, startled from his contemplation, stood abruptly.

'What are you doing here?' Noah demanded, his tone wary yet curious.

Lohengrin approached the barred gate of Noah's cell, his face shadowed by the weight of his words. 'Before Guinevere's demise, she confided in me that she suspected Loholt was behind my family's mysterious disappearance,' Lohengrin disclosed, his voice a mix of bitterness and resolve. 'She believed that all the quests she assisted me with were merely a facade—that Loholt inadvertently trapped them in another realm and couldn't devise a remedy.'

With a heavy sigh, Lohengrin opened the tome to a bookmarked page, pulling out a folded piece of parchment and sliding it through the bars to Noah. 'And I discovered this within Merlin's lost prophecies,' he added, gesturing to the paper.

Noah unfolded the parchment, revealing a prophecy that read, 'The Guardian, the king, the traveller, the survivor, the watcher, and the thief will unite to confront the monster known as Parallax.' His brow furrowed in confusion. 'This hasn't happened to me yet.'

'But you are the traveller,' Lohengrin insisted, an edge of desperation in his voice. 'A man so powerful he can morph reality at will. A man who can remember his future but is haunted by his past that he's propelled through life by the shadows behind him. I need that power, Noah.'

Noah clutched the cell bars, his eyes flickering with recognition. 'That name feels familiar. What exactly do you need from me?'

Lohengrin paced briefly before stopping, his gaze fixed on the keys hanging just out of reach. 'We all know the different elements of magic—time, soul, reality, life, and death. I believe Excalibur is the gateway to the realm of death,' he theorised. Noah glanced at his hand, where a glowing red ring encircled his finger. As Noah closed his eyes, he remembered seeing Hope, a twenty-five-year-old woman standing before him. Everything around her blurred. She said, 'Collect all the elements.' The world around him returned to the cell. Noah's hands began to glow with red magic as he lifted them towards the cell door.

Turning back with keys in hand, Lohengrin proposed, 'Will you help me enter the realm of death to rescue my family?'

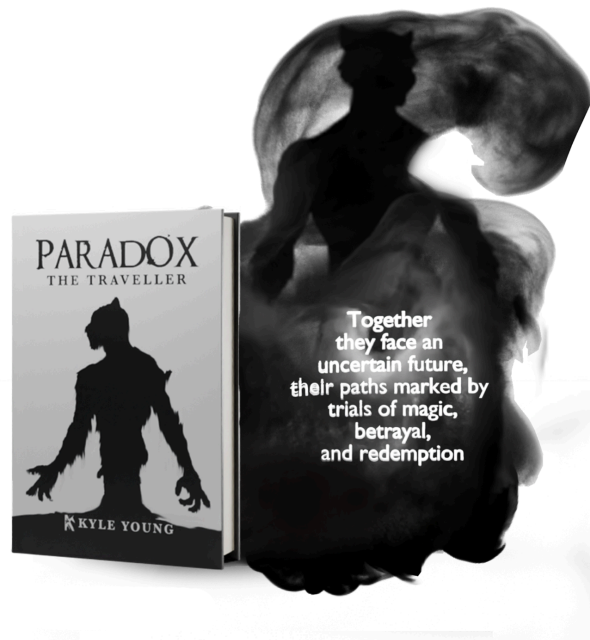
As he spoke, Lohengrin turned to find the cell door transformed into a cascade of blooming flowers, his eyes widening in astonishment. Noah stepped through the floral archway, a grin spreading across his face. 'Sounds good to me.'

Lohengrin, still in shock, dropped the keys with a clang. 'Merlin crafted these himself . . . how? And why didn't you do that sooner?'

Noah's smile widened. 'Because I was waiting for you.' With that, Noah exited the prison. Lohengrin hurried after him, both men stepping into the unknown together.

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